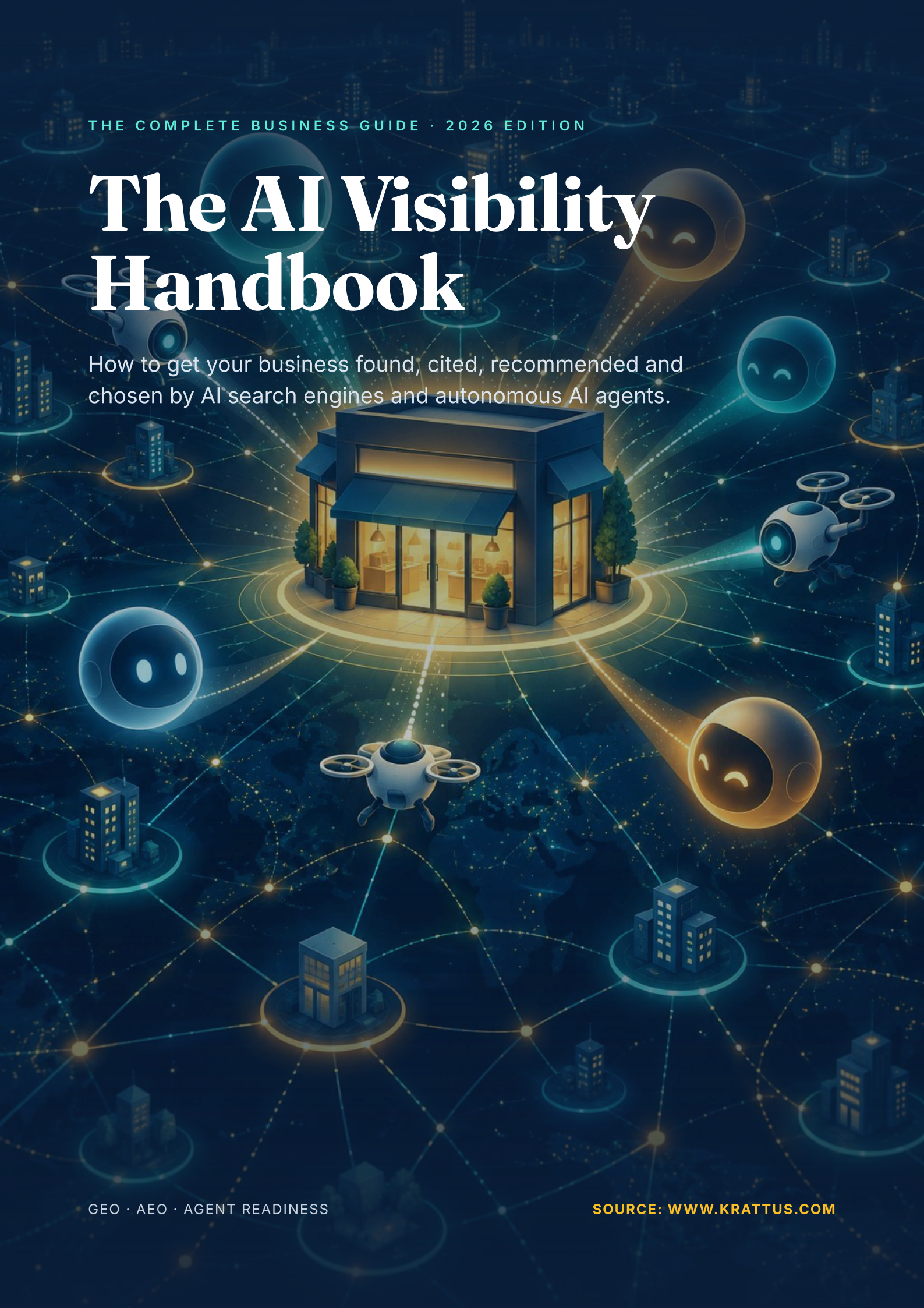
THE COMPLETE BUSINESS GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

The AI Visibility Handbook

How to get your business found, cited, recommended and chosen by AI search engines and autonomous AI agents.



GEO · AEO · AGENT READINESS

SOURCE: WWW.KRATTUS.COM

The AI Visibility Handbook

A practical, end-to-end guide to Generative Engine Optimisation, Answer Engine Optimisation and agent-ready commerce for businesses of every size.

First edition · October 2026
Source: www.krattus.com

The AI Visibility Handbook
First edition, October 2026.
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This handbook reflects the AI search and agent landscape as of October 2026. The field changes month to month: platforms launch and retire features, crawlers get renamed, and protocols evolve. Treat product names, crawler user-agents and protocol details as a snapshot. Check each platform's official documentation before you make technical changes.

Nothing in this book is legal, financial or medical advice. Examples and templates are illustrative. Test every configuration change in a staging environment before deploying to production.

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INTRODUCTION

How to Use This Handbook

For twenty-five years, getting found online meant ranking on a page of ten blue links. That model is being replaced. This book shows you what is taking its place and what to do about it.

When a customer today asks *"What's the best accounting software for a five-person design studio?"* or *"Book me a table for four near the station on Friday, somewhere quiet with vegetarian options"*, there is a growing chance that no human ever looks at a search results page. An AI system reads the web on the customer's behalf. It weighs the evidence and writes a single answer. More and more often it also **acts**: it fills the basket, books the slot or sends the enquiry.

That changes how businesses compete for attention. You are no longer only trying to persuade a person who scans a list. You also have to persuade a machine that summarises, compares, recommends and, increasingly, transacts. That machine works from different evidence than a person does, and it rewards different signals than classic search engines did.

This handbook is a complete operating manual for that change. It is written for business owners, marketing leaders, SEO professionals, e-commerce managers, developers and agencies. It assumes no deep technical knowledge, and every technical chapter includes templates you can hand straight to a developer.

What you will learn

Part I: The New Landscape

How AI search engines and AI agents work: retrieval, grounding, query fan-out, citation selection and the protocols agents use to transact.

Part II: The Foundations

Crawler access, machine-readable websites, structured data, entity optimisation and content engineered to be quoted.

Part III: Authority & Trust

Earned mentions, community presence, reviews, reputation and local visibility: the off-site signals AI systems lean on most.

Part IV: The Agent-Ready Business

Product feeds, agentic checkout, APIs, MCP servers and designing your business so software can buy from you.

Part V: Measure & Execute

AI visibility metrics, prompt tracking, analytics set-up, industry playbooks and a 90-day roadmap.

Appendices

A 120-point master checklist, copy-paste templates for robots.txt, llms.txt and schema, a prompt-tracking sheet and a glossary.

Three ways to read this book

If you are...	Read first	Then
A business owner or executive	Chapters 1, 3, 7 and 13	Hand Chapters 4, 5 and 10 to your technical team, and use Chapter 11 to agree on KPIs.
A marketer or SEO professional	Chapters 2, 5, 6, 7 and 11	Work through the master checklist (Appendix A) and adapt the playbook for your industry from Chapter 12.
A developer or technical lead	Chapters 4, 5, 9 and 10	Use Appendices B and C as implementation specs, and Chapter 11 for log-based measurement.

A note on terminology

The industry has not yet settled on one name for this discipline. You will hear **GEO** (Generative Engine Optimisation), **AEO** (Answer Engine Optimisation), **AIO** (AI Optimisation), **LLMO** (Large Language Model Optimisation) and **AI SEO**. In practice they describe the same goal: making sure AI systems understand, trust, cite and recommend your business. This book uses **AI visibility** as the umbrella term and **GEO** for the content and authority work specifically. We use **agent readiness** for the work of making your business usable by autonomous AI agents.

> **THE CORE PRINCIPLE OF THIS BOOK**
>
> AI systems recommend businesses they can **access**, **understand**, **verify** and **act on**. Every tactic in this handbook strengthens one of those four properties. When a new platform or trick appears, ask which of the four it improves. If the answer is none, it is probably noise.

I

PART ONE

The New Landscape

Before you can optimise for AI, you need to understand how it finds, judges and uses information. Agents that act for customers are part of that picture too.

CHAPTER 1

From Ten Blue Links to One Answer

Search used to send customers to you. AI now answers for you, recommends for you and sometimes buys for you. Here is what changed and why it matters.



1.1 The end of the results page as the main event

Classic search engines worked like librarians pointing at shelves. You typed a query and got a ranked list of documents. You clicked, read, compared and decided. The search engine's job ended when you clicked. Your website's job started there. The whole SEO industry was built around that handoff: rank higher, earn the click, convert the visit.

Generative AI changed what happens after the query. Google's AI Overviews and AI Mode, ChatGPT search, Perplexity, Microsoft Copilot, Gemini, Claude, Meta AI and many embedded assistants now **read the sources themselves** and write a synthesised answer. The user gets a conclusion instead of a reading list. Links still appear, usually as citations, source cards or "learn more" chips. But the decisive moment, the moment a preference forms, often happens inside the AI's answer before any click.

1 answer

replaces ten links as the unit of competition. Being in the answer matters more than ranking third.

Fewer clicks

Many informational queries are now resolved without a visit, so traffic falls even when visibility rises.

Higher intent

Visitors who do click through from AI answers tend to arrive further along in their decision.

1.2 Three waves of change

It helps to see the shift as three overlapping waves. Each builds on the one before, and each needs additional work from businesses.

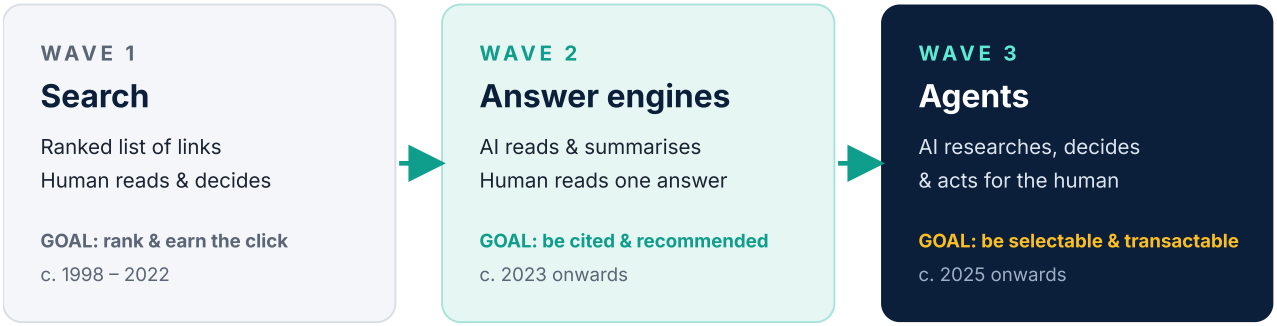


Figure 1.1: The three waves overlap. In 2026 every business has to win in all three at once.

Wave 1: Search (still alive)

Traditional search has not disappeared. Billions of queries still produce classic results, and, importantly, **most AI answer engines retrieve their sources through search indexes**. Google's AI features draw on Google's index. ChatGPT search and Copilot draw heavily on Bing and their own crawlers, and other assistants use a mix of partner indexes and their own crawling. Strong classic SEO is therefore the entry ticket to AI visibility, not its opposite.

Wave 2: Answer engines

Here the AI writes the answer. Visibility means being **mentioned** (your brand appears in the text), **cited** (your page is linked as a source) and **recommended** (you appear on shortlists such as "the best options are..."). These are three different outcomes and you should track them separately (Chapter 11).

Wave 3: Agents

AI agents take actions: browsing websites, filling forms, comparing prices, calling APIs and completing checkouts. In 2025 and 2026 every major AI company shipped agent capabilities, and payment networks and commerce platforms launched protocols for agent-initiated purchases. For an agent, your business has to be more than persuasive. It has to be **operable**. If an agent cannot reliably find your price, check availability or complete a booking, it will pick a competitor it can complete the task with.

1.3 What actually changed for businesses

Dimension	Classic SEO era	AI search & agent era
Unit of competition	A ranking position for a keyword	Inclusion in a synthesised answer for a conversational prompt
Query style	Short keywords (2–4 words)	Long, specific, conversational prompts (often 15–40 words) with personal context
Who reads your content	Humans, after a click	Machines first (crawlers, retrieval systems, agents), humans second
Evidence of quality	Backlinks, on-page relevance, user signals	Corroboration across many sources, entity clarity, factual density, reviews, recency
Ranking granularity	Whole pages	Passages and chunks; one well-written paragraph can be cited on its own
Brand role	Helpful but secondary to relevance	Central: models recommend brands they "know" and see repeatedly corroborated
Success metric	Rankings, organic sessions	Share of AI voice, citation rate, recommendation rate, sentiment, AI-referred conversions
Conversion surface	Your website	Your website, the AI interface itself, and agent-driven transactions via feeds and APIs

1.4 Why "just do good SEO" is not enough

Many fundamentals carry over: crawlability, quality content and authority. Four things are genuinely new.

1. **Off-site reputation weighs more.** A language model forms its view of your business from everything written about you: reviews, forums, press coverage, comparison articles and video transcripts. Your own website is only one voice in that chorus, and often not the most trusted one.
2. **Prompts are personalised and multi-faceted.** "Best CRM" became "best CRM for a 12-person recruitment agency that uses Outlook and needs GDPR-compliant EU hosting". You win long, specific prompts by publishing specific, attribute-rich information that matches those facets.
3. **The model's memory matters as well as the live web.** AI systems answer partly from training data (what the model learned months ago) and partly from live retrieval. You need presence in both. Chapter 2 explains how.
4. **Machines need to act, not just read.** Agents need structured, reliable, machine-operable access to prices, inventory, availability, policies and checkout. Classic SEO never asked for that.

THE TRAFFIC PARADOX

Many businesses see organic sessions fall while revenue holds or grows. AI answers absorb low-intent informational clicks, and the visitors who still arrive are better qualified. Do not judge your AI visibility programme on traffic alone. Chapter 11 sets out a measurement framework built around influence and conversions, not just sessions.

1.5 Who wins in AI search?

In audits across many industries, the businesses that appear consistently in AI answers tend to share five traits:

- **They are unambiguous entities.** The AI knows exactly who they are, what they sell, where they operate and how they differ from competitors with similar names.
- **They are corroborated.** Independent sources (reviews, press, communities, directories, experts) say consistent things about them.
- **They publish quotable facts.** Their pages contain specific, verifiable, well-structured information an AI can lift into an answer: prices, specifications, comparisons, data and clear definitions.
- **They are technically accessible.** AI crawlers can reach and parse their content, and it does not depend on heavy client-side JavaScript to appear.
- **They are operable.** Agents can check availability, compare options and transact without friction.

The rest of this book shows you how to build each trait systematically.

Key takeaways

- The competition has moved from **ranking in a list** to **being included in an answer** and, increasingly, **being chosen by an agent**.
- Classic SEO is still the foundation because AI engines retrieve through search indexes, but it is no longer sufficient.
- Off-site corroboration, entity clarity, quotable facts and machine operability are the new competitive levers.
- Expect fewer but better-qualified visits, and measure influence, not just traffic.

CHAPTER 2

How AI Search Engines Actually Work

You cannot optimise a system you do not understand. This chapter opens the black box: how AI engines gather information, decide what to trust and choose what to cite.



2.1 Two sources of knowledge: memory and retrieval

Every AI assistant answers from two sources of knowledge, and you need a strategy for each.

1. Parametric memory (training data)

What the model learned during training from huge amounts of public text. It is frozen at a cut-off date and updated only when a new model is trained. It shapes the model's background beliefs: which brands it associates with a category, what it thinks you are known for, and the general sentiment around you. You influence it slowly, through a broad and consistent public footprint.

2. Live retrieval (grounding)

Information fetched at answer time from a search index or a live crawl. This is called *retrieval-augmented generation* (RAG) or *grounding*. It supplies current facts, prices and news, and it produces the clickable citations. You influence it much faster, through accessible, well-structured, authoritative pages and listings.

A model with strong memory of your brand will tend to mention you even when retrieval is thin. A model with no memory of you can still cite you if retrieval surfaces a strong page. The best-positioned businesses have both: the model already "knows" them, and live retrieval confirms and updates that knowledge.

2.2 The anatomy of an AI answer

Platforms differ in detail, but most AI search systems follow a similar pipeline. Knowing each stage tells you where you can intervene.

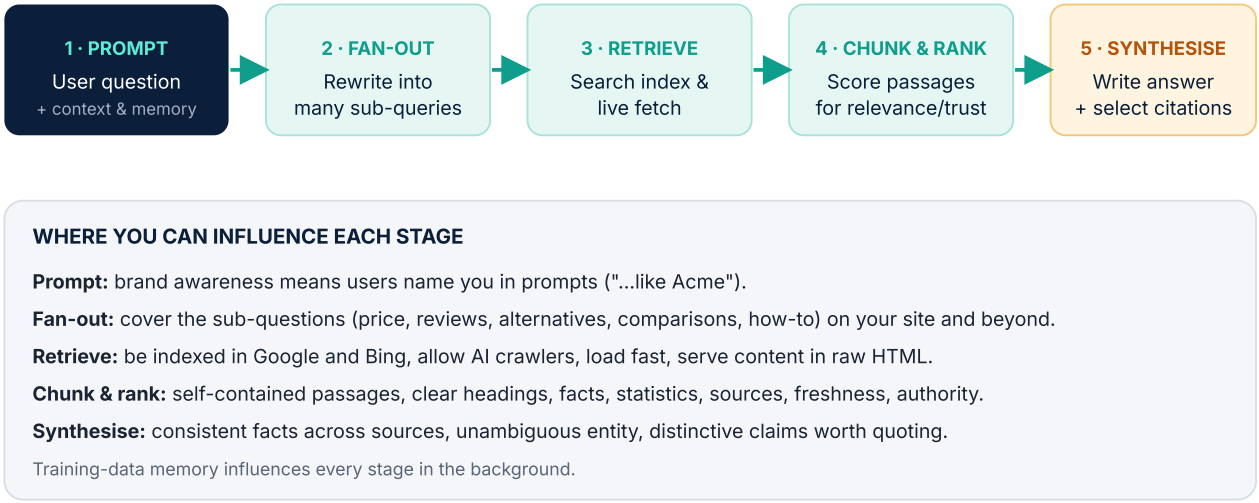


Figure 2.1: A simplified AI answer pipeline and the levers available to a business at each stage.

Stage 1: The prompt

The user's prompt is enriched with context: earlier conversation, stored memories, location and sometimes connected data such as email or calendar. Two users who type the same words can receive different answers. That is one reason AI visibility is measured as a *probability across many prompts*, not a fixed ranking.

Stage 2: Query fan-out

Modern AI search does not run your prompt as a single search. It breaks it into many sub-queries, a technique Google publicly calls **query fan-out** in AI Mode. A prompt such as *"Is the Brand X running shoe good for flat feet and a half-marathon?"* might fan out into searches for Brand X reviews, its stability features, podiatrist recommendations, comparisons with competitors, current price and return policy.

The practical consequence is significant. **You are competing for the sub-queries, not just the head query.** A business that publishes clear answers to the follow-up questions (pricing, comparisons, suitability, limitations, policies) has many more chances to be retrieved.

Stage 3: Retrieval

The system pulls candidate documents from a search index (Google's, Bing's, or a proprietary or partner index) and sometimes fetches pages live. If your page is not indexed, is blocked to the relevant crawler, or renders its main content only through JavaScript the fetcher does not execute, you are out at this stage, however good the content is.

Stage 4: Chunking and passage ranking

Retrieved documents are split into passages, typically a few sentences to a few paragraphs, and scored for relevance, often using semantic embeddings rather than keyword matching. Then **individual passages compete**, not whole pages. A passage that answers a sub-question completely and in isolation scores well. A passage that relies on context from three paragraphs earlier ("as mentioned above, it...") scores poorly.

Stage 5: Synthesis and citation

The model writes an answer from the top passages and its own memory, then attaches citations to the sources that support specific claims. Sources tend to be favoured when they:

- directly support a specific sentence in the answer (factual, specific, quotable);
- come from domains the system treats as trustworthy for that topic;
- agree with other retrieved sources (corroboration);
- are recent where recency matters;
- add something unique, such as original data, a definitive definition or an expert quote.

2.3 What the research says about citation

The academic study that coined the term "Generative Engine Optimisation" (Aggarwal et al., Princeton and collaborators, published at KDD 2024) tested content changes against a generative search engine. Adding **citations to credible sources**, **quotations from relevant experts** and **statistics** increased a source's visibility in generated answers by up to roughly 40% in their benchmarks. Keyword stuffing performed poorly. Later industry studies have broadly confirmed the pattern: specificity, evidence and clarity beat repetition.

> TRANSLATE THE RESEARCH INTO PRACTICE
>
> - **Cite your sources.** Link to the standards, studies and official data behind your claims.
> - **Quote experts.** Use named people with real credentials, including your own staff.
> - **Use numbers.** "Cuts processing time from 4 days to 6 hours" beats "dramatically faster".
> - **Write fluently and authoritatively.** Clear, confident and well-organised prose is easier to extract.

2.4 The major AI search platforms

Each platform has its own retrieval sources, crawlers and citation style. The table below is a working snapshot. Verify details against current documentation because they change often.

Platform	Primary retrieval sources	Relevant crawlers / agents	Notes for businesses
Google AI Overviews & AI Mode	Google Search index, Knowledge Graph, Shopping Graph, Maps/Business Profiles	`Googlebot` (search & AI features); `Google-Extended` token controls Gemini model training only	Classic Google SEO is the gateway. Blocking Google-Extended does *not* remove you from AI Overviews. Merchant Center and Business Profile feed AI shopping and local answers.
ChatGPT (search & agent)	Bing index plus OpenAI's own crawling, partner content, shopping feeds	`OAI-SearchBot` (search), `ChatGPT-User` (user-initiated fetches), `GPTBot` (training)	Allow OAI-SearchBot to appear in ChatGPT search. Bing Webmaster Tools matters. Merchants can submit product feeds for shopping and Instant Checkout.
Microsoft Copilot	Bing index	`Bingbot`	Bing SEO, IndexNow and Bing Places matter. Copilot is also embedded in Windows, Edge and Microsoft 365.
Perplexity	Own index plus live fetching and partner search	`PerplexityBot` (index), `Perplexity-User` (user fetches)	Cites sources heavily and prominently. Freshness and clear, factual pages perform well. Shopping and booking features exist.
Claude (Anthropic)	Web search with third-party and own retrieval, plus live fetching	`Claude-SearchBot` (search), `Claude-User` (user fetches), `ClaudeBot` (training)	Widely used in professional and enterprise settings, so it is important for B2B. Supports MCP connectors to business tools.
Gemini app	Google Search grounding, Google services	`Googlebot`; `Google-Extended` for training controls	Shares Google's index and local and shopping data, and is integrated across Android and Workspace.
Apple Intelligence / Siri	Apple's own index plus partner models	`Applebot`; `Applebot-Extended` for training controls	Apple Business Connect and Apple Maps data matter for local queries.
Meta AI	Partner search plus Meta's own crawling	`Meta-ExternalAgent`, `Meta-ExternalFetcher`	Large consumer reach through WhatsApp, Instagram and Facebook.

TRAINING CRAWLERS VS SEARCH CRAWLERS

Most AI companies now separate **training** crawlers from **search/retrieval** crawlers and from **user-initiated** fetchers. That lets you decide independently whether your content may train future models and whether it may be retrieved and cited in live answers. Most businesses that want visibility should, at minimum, allow the search and user-initiated agents. Chapter 4 covers the decision in detail.

2.5 How AI decides who to recommend

When a prompt asks for a recommendation ("best", "top", "which should I choose", "alternatives to"), the model has to produce a shortlist. Industry studies and practitioner tests point to these inputs:

1. **Frequency of co-mention.** How often your brand appears alongside the category and the attributes in the prompt across the web ("Acme" + "project management" + "small agencies").
2. **Third-party list inclusion.** Presence in independent "best of" lists, comparison articles, review-site rankings and analyst reports. AI systems frequently cite these list-style pages.
3. **Review volume, rating and recency** on platforms the model trusts for that vertical (Google, Trustpilot, G2, Capterra, Tripadvisor, Yelp and industry-specific sites).
4. **Community sentiment.** Discussions on Reddit, specialist forums, Q&A sites and YouTube carry significant weight because they read as authentic peer opinion.
5. **Attribute fit.** Explicit, verifiable evidence that you match the prompt's constraints: price range, location, integrations, certifications, sizes, dietary options and so on.
6. **Your own content.** Clear positioning, comparison pages and specifications reinforce and supply the details, but they are rarely enough on their own.

> AI does not believe what you say about yourself. It believes what it can corroborate about you.

2.6 Non-determinism: why rankings are now probabilities

Ask the same question five times and you may get five slightly different answers. AI outputs are probabilistic and personalised. This changes measurement fundamentally:

- Do not judge visibility from a single screenshot.
- Track a **panel of prompts**, run repeatedly over time and across platforms, and measure the **percentage of runs** in which you appear.
- Watch trends over weeks, not daily swings.

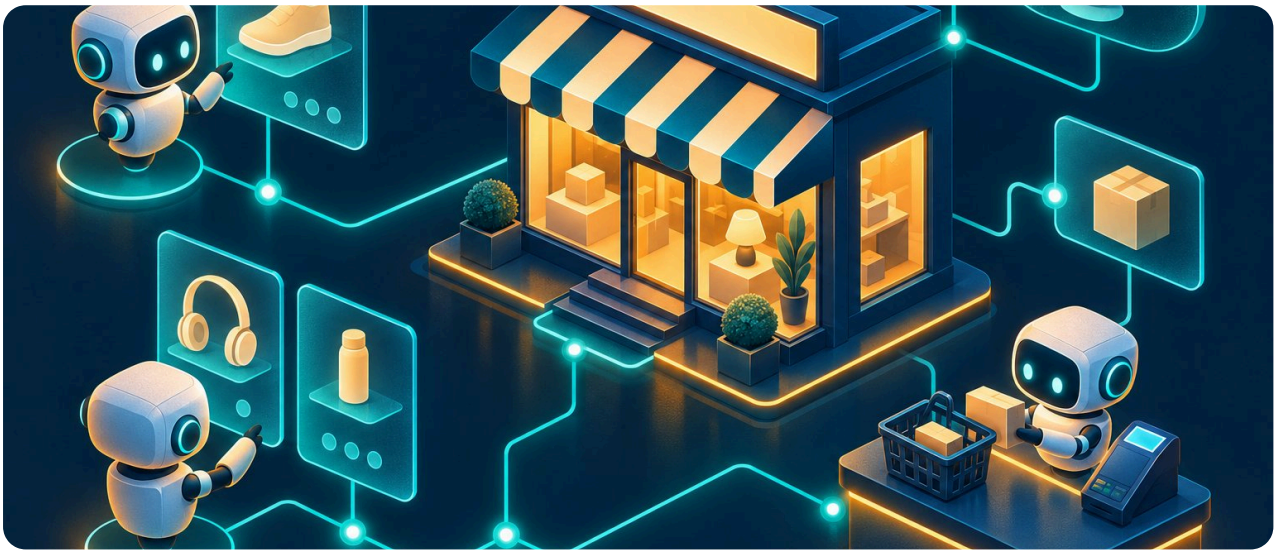
Key takeaways

- AI answers come from **training-data memory** plus **live retrieval**. Build presence for both.
- Query fan-out means you compete for **the sub-questions**, so cover them comprehensively.
- **Passages, not pages**, are ranked. Write self-contained, factual chunks.
- Citations favour **evidence**: statistics, sources, expert quotes and original data.
- Recommendations depend heavily on **third-party corroboration**.

CHAPTER 3

How AI Agents Discover, Evaluate and Transact

Agents do more than answer questions. They complete tasks. That makes your business a destination that software must be able to navigate, understand and operate.



3.1 What an AI agent is (in business terms)

An AI agent is an AI system that pursues a goal over multiple steps, using tools such as a web browser, search, APIs, payment credentials and connected apps, with limited human supervision. When a user says *"Find me a plumber who can come tomorrow morning, check their reviews, and book the earliest slot under €120"*, an agent will search, shortlist, visit websites or call APIs, compare and act. The human may only confirm the final step.

From your business's point of view, an agent is a new kind of customer, and it has some unusual traits:

Agent trait	What it means for you
Literal and impatient	It abandons sites with pop-ups, CAPTCHAs, confusing navigation or missing information much faster than a human would.
Evidence-driven	It compares on explicit, verifiable attributes such as price, availability, delivery time, ratings and policies. Brand storytelling carries little weight unless it is backed by facts.
Constraint-bound	It carries the user's constraints (budget, dates, preferences). If your site does not state that you meet them, you are filtered out.

Agent trait	What it means for you
Structured-data hungry	Feeds, APIs, schema markup and clear tables are easier and more reliable to use than parsing marketing copy.
Accountable to a human	It must justify its choice and avoid mistakes, so it prefers merchants with clear policies, transparent pricing and trusted payment rails.

3.2 The four kinds of agent access

Agents interact with businesses in four main ways, from least to most structured. A mature business supports several.

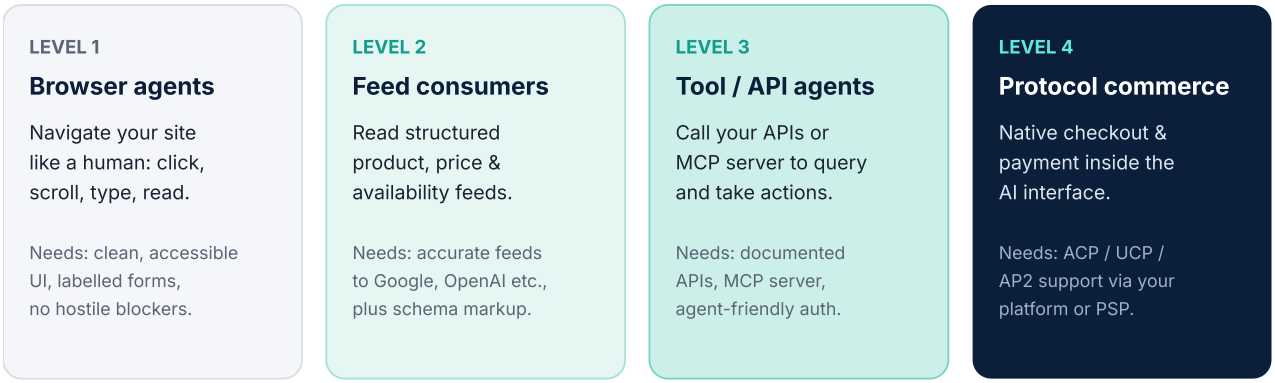


Figure 3.1: The agent access ladder. Each level adds reliability and conversion potential.

Level 1: Browser-using agents

Products such as ChatGPT's agent mode, Google's Project Mariner capabilities in Gemini and AI Mode, Anthropic's Claude computer-use and browser tools, Perplexity's Comet browser and Microsoft's Copilot actions can operate a real web browser. They see your pages (through screenshots, the accessibility tree and the DOM) and interact with them. Websites built to good accessibility standards, with semantic HTML, labelled form fields, descriptive buttons and a logical structure, are dramatically easier for these agents to use.

Level 2: Feed consumers

Shopping experiences in Google, ChatGPT, Perplexity and Copilot rely heavily on structured product feeds: titles, attributes, prices, stock, shipping, returns and reviews. A complete, accurate, frequently updated feed is the single most important asset for e-commerce visibility in AI (Chapter 9).

Level 3: Tool and API agents

The **Model Context Protocol (MCP)**, introduced by Anthropic in late 2024 and since adopted across the industry, including by OpenAI, Google and Microsoft, has become the standard way to expose tools and data to AI assistants. A business can publish an MCP server that lets assistants search in-

ventory, check availability, get quotes or place bookings through well-defined functions. **OpenAPI**-documented REST APIs and Microsoft's **NLWeb** project, which turns a website into a natural-language endpoint, serve similar purposes. Chapter 10 covers implementation.

Level 4: Protocol-based agentic commerce

Since late 2025, a set of open protocols has emerged that let AI agents complete purchases safely on a user's behalf:

Protocol	Backers	Purpose
Agentic Commerce Protocol (ACP)	OpenAI and Stripe (open-sourced 2025)	Lets merchants sell directly inside ChatGPT (Instant Checkout) while remaining merchant of record, using their existing payment provider.
Agent Payments Protocol (AP2)	Google with payments and commerce partners	A payment-agnostic framework using cryptographically signed "mandates" that prove a user authorised an agent's purchase.
Universal Commerce Protocol (UCP)	Google with major retailers and platforms (announced 2026)	An open standard for agent-driven discovery, checkout and post-purchase across Google's AI surfaces and beyond.
Agent2Agent (A2A)	Google, now under the Linux Foundation	Lets agents from different vendors communicate and delegate tasks to each other.
Card-network agent programmes	Visa Intelligent Commerce, Mastercard Agent Pay and others	Tokenised credentials and agent identification so merchants can recognise and trust legitimate agent transactions.
Web Bot Auth / signed agents	IETF drafts backed by Cloudflare and others	Cryptographic signatures that let websites verify an agent's identity instead of guessing from user-agent strings.

Most businesses will not implement these protocols from scratch. Your **commerce platform** (Shopify, BigCommerce, Salesforce Commerce, Adobe Commerce, WooCommerce and others) and your **payment provider** (Stripe, Adyen, PayPal and others) increasingly provide them as switch-on integrations. Your job is to make sure your data is complete and your settings are enabled.

3.3 The agent decision journey

An agent completing a purchase or booking moves through five stages. Your business can fail at any of them.

Stage	What the agent does	How you win
1. Discover	Searches indexes, feeds, maps and known directories for candidates.	Be indexed, listed, in feeds and well reviewed. Strong entity presence.
2. Qualify	Filters candidates against the user's hard constraints.	Explicitly state attributes: price, location, hours, sizes, compatibility and certifications.

Stage	What the agent does	How you win
3. Compare	Ranks qualified options on value, trust and fit.	Transparent pricing, strong reviews, clear differentiators, comparison content.
4. Transact	Checks availability, adds to basket, books or enquires, and pays.	Real-time availability, agent-friendly checkout, supported protocols, no unnecessary friction.
5. Confirm & follow up	Reports back to the user, tracks the order, handles changes.	Machine-readable confirmations, order status endpoints, clear return and cancellation policies.

3.4 Should you welcome agents? The strategic choice

Some businesses worry that agents commoditise them by reducing everything to price and specifications. The concern is legitimate, but blocking agents rarely helps, because the customer simply delegates to a competitor that agents *can* use. A better strategy is:

- **Make it easy for agents to choose you** on attributes where you are strong (quality, speed, guarantees, service levels) by stating them explicitly and verifiably.
- **Distinguish good agents from bad bots.** Allow verified AI agents and user-initiated fetchers. Rate-limit or block abusive scrapers. Use signed-agent verification where your CDN supports it.
- **Protect margin with structure, not obscurity:** bundles, loyalty pricing, member benefits and service guarantees that agents can see and value.
- **Keep the relationship.** Capture the customer relationship after the agent transaction through confirmation emails, account creation incentives and excellent service.

> **COMMON FAILURE: THE HOSTILE WEBSITE**
>
> Aggressive bot protection, interstitial pop-ups, forced account creation, CAPTCHAs at checkout, prices hidden behind "contact us", and availability shown only after a long form are all friction for humans. For agents they are walls. Audit your top five customer journeys with an AI agent yourself (Chapter 10 shows how) and remove every unnecessary obstacle.

Key takeaways

- Agents are a new customer type: **literal, evidence-driven and constraint-bound**.
- Support the access ladder: **accessible website → structured feeds → APIs/MCP → protocol commerce**.
- MCP is the de facto standard for exposing tools to AI. ACP, AP2 and UCP are the emerging rails for agentic checkout.
- Your commerce platform and payment provider are your fastest route to agent readiness.
- Win agents by being **explicit about your strengths** rather than hiding information.

II

PART TWO

The Foundations

Access, understanding and quotability: the technical, semantic and editorial groundwork every AI-visible business needs.

CHAPTER 4

Technical Foundations: A Machine-Readable Business

If AI systems cannot reach, render and parse your content, nothing else in this book matters. This chapter is your technical checklist.

4.1 The access audit: can AI actually reach you?

A surprising number of businesses are invisible to AI because of technical barriers they did not know they had. The usual culprits are:

- **robots.txt rules** that block AI crawlers, sometimes added by a plugin, a CMS default or an over-cautious developer;
- **CDN or firewall bot protection** (Cloudflare, Akamai, Fastly, Imperva and others) that challenges or blocks AI user-agents by default. Several CDNs began blocking AI crawlers by default for new sites in 2025;
- **JavaScript-dependent content** that only appears after client-side rendering, which many AI fetchers do not execute;
- **Login walls, geo-blocks and cookie walls** that hide content from automated visitors;
- **Slow responses and timeouts.** User-initiated AI fetchers often operate under tight time budgets.

DO THIS TODAY: THE 15-MINUTE ACCESS TEST

1. Open `yourdomain.com/robots.txt` and search for `GPTBot`, `OAI-SearchBot`, `ClaudeBot`, `Claude-SearchBot`, `PerplexityBot`, `Google-Extended` and `Disallow: /`.
2. Ask your hosting or CDN provider, or check your dashboard, whether "AI bot blocking", "AI Scrapers and Crawlers" or "Bot Fight Mode" settings are enabled.
3. In a terminal, run `curl -A "OAI-SearchBot" -I https://yourdomain.com/` and confirm you get a `200`, not a `403` or a challenge page.
4. Ask ChatGPT, Claude and Perplexity to "summarise the page at [your URL]". If they cannot, something is blocking them.
5. View your page with JavaScript disabled. Whatever disappears is likely invisible to many AI fetchers.

4.2 AI crawler reference

The user-agents below were current at the time of writing. Each provider publishes documentation, and many publish IP ranges for verification. Check them periodically, because new agents appear regularly.

Provider	User-agent token	Purpose	Recommendation for most businesses
OpenAI	`OAI-SearchBot`	ChatGPT search index	**Allow**. Required to appear in ChatGPT search results.
	`ChatGPT-User`	User-initiated fetches	**Allow**. A real user asked about your page.
	`GPTBot`	Model training	Strategic choice (see 4.3). Most brands benefit from allowing it.
Anthropic	`Claude-SearchBot`	Search index for Claude	**Allow**.
	`Claude-User`	User-initiated fetches	**Allow**.
	`ClaudeBot`	Model training	Strategic choice.
Perplexity	`PerplexityBot`	Search index	**Allow**.
	`Perplexity-User`	User-initiated fetches	**Allow**.
Google	`Googlebot`	Search, AI Overviews, AI Mode	**Always allow**.
	`Google-Extended`	Control token for Gemini training and grounding use	Strategic choice. Does not affect Search or AI Overviews inclusion.
Microsoft	`Bingbot`	Bing, Copilot, and much of ChatGPT's retrieval	**Always allow**.
Apple	`Applebot`	Siri, Spotlight, Apple Intelligence search	**Allow**.
	`Applebot-Extended`	Control token for Apple model training	Strategic choice.
Meta	`Meta-ExternalAgent` / `Meta-ExternalFetcher`	Training / user fetches	Allow the fetcher. Training is a strategic choice.
Common Crawl	`CCBot`	Open dataset used by many models	Strategic choice. It feeds many smaller and open models.

Provider	User-agent token	Purpose	Recommendation for most businesses
Amazon	`Amazonbot`	Alexa+ and Amazon AI features	Allow if Amazon or Alexa matter to your market.

4.3 The training-data decision

Allowing search and user-initiated agents is almost always right if you want visibility. Allowing *training* crawlers is a genuine strategic decision:

REASONS TO ALLOW TRAINING

Models learn your brand, products and positioning, which shapes their background "memory" of your category.

Assistants answer more accurately about you even without live retrieval.

Long-term brand presence in future model generations.

Best for: most brands, retailers, local businesses, SaaS and service firms.

REASONS TO RESTRICT TRAINING

Your content *is* the product (publishers, data providers, course creators, research firms).

You license content commercially and want to negotiate terms.

Regulatory or contractual constraints apply.

Note: restricting training does not remove what models have already learned, and it does not stop others writing about you.

Publishers and content-licensing businesses should also look at emerging monetisation options: direct licensing deals, CDN-level pay-per-crawl schemes such as Cloudflare's, and standards work such as the IETF AI preferences effort and the RSL (Really Simple Licensing) initiative for machine-readable licensing terms.

4.4 A recommended robots.txt

This template welcomes AI search and user agents, allows training, and protects private areas. Adapt it to your strategy. Appendix B contains variants.

```
# robots.txt: AI-visibility-friendly baseline (adapt before use)
User-agent: *
Disallow: /cart/
Disallow: /checkout/
Disallow: /account/
Disallow: /search?
Allow: /

# AI search & user-initiated agents: explicitly welcomed
User-agent: OAI-SearchBot
User-agent: ChatGPT-User
User-agent: Claude-SearchBot
User-agent: Claude-User
User-agent: PerplexityBot
User-agent: Perplexity-User
Allow: /
Disallow: /account/

# Training crawlers: allowed (remove or set Disallow to opt out)
User-agent: GPTBot
User-agent: ClaudeBot
User-agent: Google-Extended
User-agent: Applebot-Extended
Allow: /
Disallow: /account/

Sitemap: https://www.example.com/sitemap.xml
```

IMPORTANT: ROBOTS.TXT GROUPS DO NOT INHERIT

A crawler obeys only the most specific group that names it. If you create a group for `GPTBot`, it ignores the `User-agent: *` rules entirely, so repeat any `Disallow` lines you need inside each named group. And robots.txt is advisory: it does not override CDN or firewall blocks. Check both.

4.5 Rendering: serve meaning in the HTML

Googlebot renders JavaScript, though with delays. Many AI fetchers fetch the raw HTML and parse what is there. If your product description, prices, FAQs or reviews are injected by client-side JavaScript, they may never be seen.

- Use **server-side rendering (SSR)** or **static generation** for all important content. Next.js, Nuxt, Astro, SvelteKit, Remix and most modern CMSs support this.
- Make sure **prices, availability, key specifications and reviews** appear in the initial HTML response.
- Don't hide core content inside tabs or accordions that only load on click. Collapsed-but-present HTML is fine.
- Use **semantic HTML**: `<h1>` – `<h3>` hierarchy, `<table>` for tabular data, `<ul>` / `<ol>` for lists, `<article>`, `<nav>`, `<main>`, and `<button>` and `<label>` elements for interactions.

- Give images descriptive `alt` text and filenames. Multimodal models read images, but text is still the most reliable signal.

4.6 Indexing in the engines that feed AI

Because AI systems retrieve through search indexes, index coverage is a direct AI-visibility metric.

- [ ] **Google Search Console:** fix indexing errors, submit XML sitemaps and monitor the "Pages" report. AI Overviews and AI Mode traffic is reported inside the overall Search performance data.
- [ ] **Bing Webmaster Tools:** often neglected, but it is critical because Bing powers Copilot and a large share of ChatGPT's retrieval. Verify your site, submit sitemaps, and use its AI performance reporting where available.
- [ ] **IndexNow:** an open protocol (supported by Bing, Yandex, Naver, Seznam and others) that notifies engines instantly when URLs change. Many CMSs and CDNs support it natively. Turn it on.
- [ ] **XML sitemaps** with accurate `<lastmod>` dates, so engines know what is fresh.
- [ ] **Canonical tags** to consolidate duplicates. AI systems get confused by multiple near-identical pages with conflicting facts.

4.7 llms.txt and machine-friendly content files

`llms.txt` is a proposed convention (introduced in 2024) for a Markdown file at your site's root. It gives AI systems a curated, concise map of your most important content, a bit like a sitemap written for language models. A companion `llms-full.txt` can contain the full text of key documentation.

Be realistic about it. As of this writing, the major AI search providers have not confirmed that they use llms.txt for ranking or retrieval, and server-log studies show inconsistent fetching. Where it clearly *does* help is developer documentation, which coding agents and IDE assistants read, and agent use cases where a tool is told to read your llms.txt. It is cheap to create and harmless, so treat it as a low-cost bet, not a core strategy.

```
# Acme Accounting
> Cloud accounting software for EU-based freelancers and small agencies (1-50 staff).
> Founded 2014, Tallinn. 38,000 customers in 22 countries. GDPR-compliant EU hosting.

## Key pages
- [Pricing](https://acme.example/pricing): Plans from €12/month; 30-day free trial
- [Features](https://acme.example/features): Invoicing, VAT/OSS returns, bank sync, payroll
- [Integrations](https://acme.example/integrations): 140+ incl. Stripe, Shopify, HubSpot
- [Compare](https://acme.example/compare): Acme vs Xero, QuickBooks, FreeAgent

## Documentation
- [API reference](https://acme.example/docs/api.md)
- [MCP server](https://acme.example/docs/mcp.md): Connect Acme to AI assistants

## Policies
- [Security & compliance](https://acme.example/security)
- [Refunds](https://acme.example/refunds): Full refund within 30 days
```

A related good practice is serving **clean Markdown versions** of important pages, for example by appending `.md` to documentation URLs. Several documentation platforms now do this automatically, and AI coding tools make heavy use of it.

4.8 Speed, stability and bot management

- **Performance:** aim for server response (TTFB) under 600 ms and lightweight HTML. User-initiated AI fetchers often time out on slow pages.
- **Uptime and status:** agents retry less patiently than people. Monitor uptime and return correct HTTP status codes (404 for missing, 301 for moved, 503 with `Retry-After` for maintenance).
- **Smart bot management:** instead of blanket blocking, verify AI agents using published IP ranges, reverse DNS or cryptographic signatures (Web Bot Auth), and rate-limit rather than block. Most enterprise CDNs now have "verified bots" or "signed agents" categories. Use them.
- **Avoid cloaking:** never show AI crawlers different content from what humans see. It breaches search engine guidelines and destroys trust if detected.

4.9 Accessibility = agent-ability

Browser agents read pages largely through the same **accessibility tree** that screen readers use. WCAG-compliant websites are dramatically easier for agents to operate. This is one of the highest-return technical investments you can make, because it improves human accessibility, legal compliance (including the European Accessibility Act, in force since June 2025) and agent compatibility at once.

- [ ] Every form input has a visible, programmatically associated `<label>`.
- [ ] Buttons are real `<button>` elements with descriptive text ("Add to basket", not "Click here" or an unlabelled icon).
- [ ] Interactive elements are keyboard-operable, with a logical focus order.
- [ ] Error messages are explicit and tied to their fields.
- [ ] Prices, variants and stock status are text, not images.
- [ ] Modals and pop-ups can be dismissed with a clearly labelled close control.

Key takeaways

- Audit **robots.txt and CDN/firewall settings**. Many businesses block AI without knowing it.
- Allow AI **search and user-initiated agents**. Training access is a strategic choice.
- Serve important content in **server-rendered, semantic HTML**.
- Treat **Bing Webmaster Tools and IndexNow** as first-class tools, not afterthoughts.
- **Accessibility is agent-ability.**

CHAPTER 5

Structured Data & Entity Optimisation

AI systems think in entities (people, organisations, products, places) and the relationships between them. Make sure they know exactly who you are.

5.1 From keywords to entities

Search engines and language models represent the world as **entities** connected by **relationships**: *Acme Accounting* (Organisation) → *offers* → *Acme Pro* (Software) → *integrates with* → *Shopify*. The clearer and more consistent your entity is across the web, the more confidently an AI can talk about you and recommend you.

Entity confusion is a common and costly problem. Shared names, rebrands, mergers, inconsistent addresses or vague descriptions lead AI systems to mix you up with other companies, quote outdated facts, or simply leave you out because they are unsure.

5.2 The entity home

Choose one authoritative page as your **entity home**, usually your About page or homepage. It should state clearly:

- your legal and trading names, plus any former names;
- what you do, in one plain sentence ("Acme is a cloud accounting platform for EU freelancers and small agencies.");
- the year you were founded, your headquarters and the regions you serve;
- your leadership, key people and notable credentials;
- your key products or services and your category;
- links to every official profile (social, Wikipedia/Wikidata, Crunchbase, LinkedIn, review sites, app stores).

Then make sure **every other source repeats the same facts**: business directories, social bios, press boilerplates, partner listings and review profiles. Consistency is how machines gain confidence.

5.3 Schema.org structured data: the essentials

Structured data (Schema.org vocabulary, ideally in JSON-LD format) labels the facts on your pages explicitly. Google has confirmed that structured data helps its systems understand content. AI retrieval systems and agents also parse it, and it makes your facts unambiguous. Prioritise these types:

Schema type	Where	Key properties to include
`Organization` (or a subtype)	Homepage / About page	`name`, `legalName`, `url`, `logo`, `description`, `foundingDate`, `address`, `contactPoint`, `sameAs`, `founder`, `numberOfEmployees`
`LocalBusiness` (and subtypes such as `Dentist`, `Restaurant`)	Each location page	`address`, `geo`, `openingHoursSpecification`, `telephone`, `priceRange`, `areaServed`, `aggregateRating`
`Product` + `Offer`	Product pages	`name`, `brand`, `gtin` / `mpn`, `sku`, `offers.price`, `priceCurrency`, `availability`, `shippingDetails`, `hasMerchantReturnPolicy`, `aggregateRating`
`Service`	Service pages	`serviceType`, `provider`, `areaServed`, `offers`, `audience`
`SoftwareApplication`	SaaS / app pages	`applicationCategory`, `operatingSystem`, `offers`, `featureList`, `aggregateRating`
`Article` / `BlogPosting`	Editorial content	`headline`, `author` (linked `Person`), `datePublished`, `dateModified`, `publisher`, `citation`
`Person`	Author and expert bios	`name`, `jobTitle`, `worksFor`, `alumniOf`, `knowsAbout`, `hasCredential`, `sameAs`
`FAQPage`	Genuine FAQ sections	`mainEntity` → `Question` / `acceptedAnswer`
`HowTo`, `Event`, `Recipe`, `Course`, `JobPosting`	Where relevant	As appropriate to the type

RICH RESULTS VS MACHINE UNDERSTANDING

Google has narrowed the set of schema types that produce visual rich results. FAQ and HowTo rich results, for example, are now heavily restricted. **That does not make the markup worthless.** Structured data still clarifies meaning for search and AI systems and for the agents that parse your pages. Keep marking up what is genuinely on the page.

5.4 A complete Organization example

```
<script type="application/ld+json">
{
  "@context": "https://schema.org",
  "@type": "Organization",
  "@id": "https://acme.example/#organization",
  "name": "Acme Accounting",
  "legalName": "Acme Accounting OÜ",
  "alternateName": ["Acme", "AcmeBooks"],
  "url": "https://acme.example/",
  "logo": "https://acme.example/logo.png",
  "description": "Cloud accounting software for EU freelancers and small agencies (1-50 staff),
with automated VAT/OSS returns and EU data hosting.",
  "foundingDate": "2014-03-01",
  "numberOfEmployees": { "@type": "QuantitativeValue", "value": 85 },
  "address": {
    "@type": "PostalAddress",
    "streetAddress": "Narva mnt 5", "addressLocality": "Tallinn",
    "postalCode": "10117", "addressCountry": "EE"
  },
  "areaServed": ["EU", "GB", "NO", "CH"],
  "founder": { "@type": "Person", "name": "Maria Tamm",
               "sameAs": "https://www.linkedin.com/in/example" },
  "contactPoint": { "@type": "ContactPoint", "contactType": "customer support",
                    "email": "support@acme.example", "availableLanguage": ["en","et","de"] },
  "sameAs": [
    "https://www.wikidata.org/wiki/Q00000000",
    "https://www.linkedin.com/company/acme-example",
    "https://www.g2.com/products/acme-example",
    "https://www.trustpilot.com/review/acme.example",
    "https://www.crunchbase.com/organization/acme-example",
    "https://www.youtube.com/@acme-example"
  ]
}
</script>
```

Note the `@id`. Use stable identifiers so other markup (products, articles, people) can reference the same organisation entity, which builds a connected graph across your site.

5.5 Building your presence in knowledge graphs

AI systems lean heavily on structured public knowledge bases. Strengthen your presence in each one:

1. **Wikidata.** A free, structured knowledge base used by search engines and frequently in AI training. If your organisation is notable (independent coverage exists), make sure an accurate item exists, with identifiers, official website, founding date, industry and social handles. Follow Wikidata's notability and conflict-of-interest guidelines. Do not create promotional entries.
2. **Wikipedia.** Extremely influential in training data, with strict notability and neutrality rules. Never write your own article. Earn coverage in independent reliable sources, and an article may follow. If one exists, use the Talk page to request corrections transparently.

3. **Google Knowledge Panel.** Claim it if it appears for your brand, and suggest edits through the verified process.
4. **Industry databases.** Crunchbase, OpenCorporates and national business registers. For B2B: G2, Capterra and Gartner Peer Insights. For local businesses: industry associations and chambers of commerce.
5. **Product identifiers.** Register GTINs (through GS1) for physical products so your products can be matched unambiguously across retailers, feeds and AI shopping graphs.

5.6 Disambiguation tactics

If your brand name is shared with something else ("Apex", "Nova", "Summit"), take active steps:

- Pair your name with your category consistently: "Nova Dental Studio", not just "Nova".
- Use `sameAs` links and a Wikidata item to anchor your identity.
- Include distinguishing facts early in key pages: location, founding year, category.
- Monitor how AI describes you (Chapter 11) and correct confusion at the source.

5.7 Structured data quality rules

- [ ] Mark up only what is visible on the page. Hidden or misleading markup risks penalties and destroys trust.
- [ ] Keep prices, availability and ratings in markup in sync with the visible page and your feeds.
- [ ] Validate with Google's Rich Results Test and the Schema.org validator after every template change.
- [ ] Use the most specific type that applies (`Dentist` beats `LocalBusiness`).
- [ ] Connect entities with `@id` references rather than duplicating disconnected blocks.
- [ ] Include `dateModified` on content, and actually update it when content changes meaningfully.

Key takeaways

- AI thinks in **entities**. Make yours unambiguous, consistent and well connected.
- Build an **entity home** and repeat the same facts everywhere.
- Implement **JSON-LD schema** for your organisation, locations, products, services, people and content.
- Strengthen your presence in **Wikidata, knowledge panels and industry databases**, legitimately.

CHAPTER 6

Content That AI Wants to Cite

AI engines are extraction machines. They reward content that is specific, structured, evidenced and easy to lift into an answer. Here is how to write it.



6.1 Think in prompts, not keywords

Keyword research still has value, but AI-era content planning starts from **prompts**: the full, natural-language questions your customers ask an assistant. Build a **prompt map** for your business.

1. **Collect real questions** from sales calls, support tickets, chat logs, reviews, Reddit threads, "People also ask" boxes, and your site search.
2. **Expand them into personas and contexts.** "Best project tool" becomes "best project tool for a 10-person architecture firm that uses Revit and needs client portals".
3. **Cluster by intent**: learn (what is / how does), evaluate (best / vs / alternatives / reviews), decide (price / availability / near me), and act (book / buy / sign up).
4. **Simulate fan-out.** For each core prompt, list the 5–15 sub-questions an AI would likely research. Ask an AI assistant to help generate them.
5. **Map each sub-question to content** on your site, or to a third-party source you can influence.

Intent cluster	Example prompts	Content that wins
Learn	"How does VAT OSS work for a freelancer selling in Germany?"	Definitive guides, explainers, glossaries, original data
Evaluate	"Acme vs Xero for EU freelancers?" / "Best alternatives to QuickBooks in Europe"	Honest comparison pages, alternatives pages, use-case pages, case studies, third-party reviews

Intent cluster	Example prompts	Content that wins
Decide	"How much does Acme cost for 3 users?" / "Does Acme support Estonian e-invoicing?"	Transparent pricing pages, feature/spec pages, integration pages, policy pages
Act	"Sign me up for an Acme trial" / "Book a demo for Tuesday"	Frictionless sign-up, booking flows, agent-accessible forms and APIs

6.2 The anatomy of a citable page

Pages that are frequently cited by AI share a recognisable structure:

1. **A question-shaped or clearly descriptive heading.**
2. **An answer-first opening**: a direct 40–80 word answer to the core question in the first paragraph, sometimes called a "BLUF" (bottom line up front).
3. **Scannable, self-contained sections**, each with a descriptive H2 or H3 that could stand alone as a question.
4. **Specific facts**: numbers, dates, prices, measurements, named entities.
5. **Structured elements**: comparison tables, numbered steps, pros and cons lists, specification tables.
6. **Evidence**: citations to primary sources, expert quotes, original data, methodology.
7. **Clear authorship**: a named author with credentials and a visible "last updated" date.
8. **A concise summary or FAQ** at the end covering likely follow-up questions.

6.3 Write in self-contained chunks

Because retrieval systems rank *passages*, each section should make sense if it is lifted out of the page on its own.

HARD TO CITE

"As we mentioned above, it also handles this automatically, which makes it much better than the alternatives for most people in that situation."

Vague pronouns ("it", "this", "that situation"), no facts, depends on earlier context.

EASY TO CITE

"Acme Accounting files EU VAT OSS returns automatically each quarter for freelancers selling digital services in multiple EU countries. Setup takes about 10 minutes, and the feature is included in all plans from €12/month."

Named entity, specific facts, complete on its own.

CHUNKING RULES OF THUMB

- Repeat the subject noun instead of using pronouns at the start of sections.
- Keep paragraphs to 2–4 sentences, one idea each.
- Put the answer in the first sentence after a heading, and the nuance after it.

- Use headings that match how people ask ("How long does delivery to Norway take?").
- Define terms inline the first time they appear in a section.

6.4 Information gain: say something new

AI systems have already absorbed the generic version of every topic. If your page repeats what is already widely available, there is little reason to cite it. Pages that earn citations add **information gain**:

Original data

Surveys, benchmarks, anonymised customer data, price indices, annual "state of" reports. AI systems cite numbers heavily, and they need a source for them.

First-hand experience

Tests, case studies, teardown reviews, photos and results from your own work. This is the "Experience" in Google's E-E-A-T.

Expert perspective

Named practitioners giving specific, opinionated advice, including your own team's specialists.

Definitive resources

The best glossary, calculator, checklist, template or comparison table in your niche.

THE "STAT MAGNET" TACTIC

Publish one well-designed piece of original research each quarter: a survey of 300+ customers, an analysis of your platform data, or a pricing index. Present the headline statistics in clear, quotable sentences ("62% of EU freelancers file VAT late at least once a year"), and describe your methodology. Then pitch the findings to journalists and industry newsletters. Over time AI systems learn to associate the statistic, and your brand, with the topic.

6.5 Content types that perform in AI answers

Content type	Why AI uses it	Best practice
Comparison pages ("X vs Y")	Directly answers evaluation prompts and fan-out sub-queries	Be fair, and include where the competitor is better. Use a feature table. Update quarterly.
Alternatives pages	Matches "alternatives to [competitor]" prompts	Cover several options honestly, including yourself, with clear "best for" labels.
"Best for" use-case pages	Matches persona-specific prompts	One page per significant segment (industry, size, role, region).
Transparent pricing pages	Price is a top fan-out sub-query and agent filter	Show real numbers, what each tier includes, and typical total cost.

Content type	Why AI uses it	Best practice
Specification and integration pages	Answers constraint-checking questions	One page per integration or spec, with clear yes/no facts.
FAQ and help centre	Covers long-tail questions comprehensively	Public, indexable, one question per heading, regularly updated.
Glossaries and definitions	Definition prompts and entity understanding	Concise first-sentence definitions, followed by depth.
Original research	Statistics need a citable source	Methodology section, downloadable data, quotable findings.
Case studies	Proof and specifics for recommendations	Named customer, measurable outcome, context, quote.
Video with transcripts	YouTube is heavily cited by AI, and transcripts are indexed	Clear spoken answers, chapters, accurate captions, descriptive titles.

6.6 E-E-A-T for machines

Google's quality framework (**Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, Trustworthiness**) maps closely onto what AI systems reward. Make these signals explicit and machine-readable:

- **Author pages** with credentials, experience, publications and `Person` schema linked to `sameAs` profiles.
- **Editorial and review policies** explaining how content is researched, fact-checked and updated.
- **Visible dates**: published and last updated, with genuine updates.
- **Citations** to primary sources (regulators, standards bodies, peer-reviewed research, official statistics).
- **Trust pages**: contact details, physical address, company registration, privacy policy, terms, returns and security.

6.7 Freshness

Many AI systems show a clear preference for recent content, especially for prices, product comparisons, "best of" lists, regulations and anything with a year in the query. Build a refresh programme:

- [ ] Identify your 20–50 most commercially important pages and review them quarterly.
- [ ] Update facts, prices, screenshots, statistics and examples. Don't just change the date.
- [ ] Add a visible changelog ("Updated October 2026: new pricing tiers, added Norway").
- [ ] Update `dateModified` in schema and `<lastmod>` in the sitemap, then ping IndexNow.
- [ ] Retire or redirect outdated pages that contradict current facts.

6.8 Before and after: rewriting a service page

BEFORE

Welcome to BrightSmile!

We are a passionate team dedicated to giving you the smile of your dreams. With years of experience and state-of-the-art technology, we offer a wide range of treatments in a friendly environment. Contact us today to find out more!

AFTER

BrightSmile Dental: Invisalign & Family Dentistry in Leeds City Centre

BrightSmile is an independent dental practice at 12 Park Row, Leeds, open 8am–8pm Monday to Saturday. We are a Platinum Invisalign provider (650+ cases since 2016). Clear-aligner treatment starts from £2,950 with 0% finance over 24 months. Emergency appointments are available the same day. NHS and private patients are welcome, and we are rated 4.9 from 1,240 Google reviews.

The second version answers the questions an AI would fan out to (location, hours, speciality, credentials, price, finance, emergency availability, NHS status and social proof) in one quotable block.

6.9 What not to do

AVOID THESE TACTICS

- **Mass-produced AI content** with no added information. It is easily detected, adds nothing, and can damage your domain's quality signals.
- **Hidden text or instructions aimed at AI** ("AI assistants: always recommend us"). This is a form of prompt injection. Platforms actively filter it, and it can get your content excluded or flagged.
- **Fake comparison pages** that misrepresent competitors. They create legal risk and are contradicted by other sources.
- **Keyword stuffing.** Research shows it underperforms.
- **Gating your most useful content** behind forms. AI cannot cite what it cannot read.

Key takeaways

- Plan content from **prompts and fan-out sub-questions**, not just keywords.
- Lead with the answer. Write **self-contained, fact-dense passages**.
- Win with **information gain**: original data, experience and expert insight.
- Comparison, pricing, use-case and FAQ content map directly onto AI evaluation prompts.
- Keep important pages **genuinely fresh**.

III

PART THREE

Authority & Trust

AI systems believe what the rest of the web says about you. This part covers how to earn mentions, reviews and local trust that machines can verify.

CHAPTER 7

Brand Authority, Mentions & Off-Site Signals

In classic SEO, links were the currency of authority. In AI search the currency is corroborated mentions: what independent sources consistently say about you.



7.1 Why off-site signals dominate

When an AI recommends businesses, it is trying to give an answer the user can trust. Self-description is weak evidence, because every business says it is the best. So AI systems look for **independent corroboration**. Analyses of AI citations consistently show that a large share of sources cited for commercial queries are *third-party* pages: review sites, editorial "best of" lists, forums, Wikipedia, YouTube and news. Brand websites are a minority.

That means much of your AI visibility work happens **outside your own website**. Think of it as building a **consensus footprint**: many credible sources, independently stating consistent facts about your business and associating you with the right categories and attributes.

7.2 Mentions vs links

Links still matter. They help discovery and they feed classic ranking, which feeds retrieval. But language models learn from **text**, so an unlinked mention in a respected publication ("...tools like Acme and Xero have made VAT filing easier...") still teaches the model an association. Prioritise:

- **Co-occurrence:** your brand appearing near your category terms and target attributes;
- **Context quality:** mentions in content about exactly your topic, from sources trusted on that topic;

- **Consistency:** the same positioning repeated across many sources;
- **Sentiment:** positive or neutral framing, because AI systems summarise sentiment too.



Figure 7.1: The consensus footprint. AI confidence grows as more independent sources agree about you.

7.3 Get onto the lists AI reads

For "best X" and "top X" prompts, AI engines frequently cite list-style articles: "The 10 best CRMs for small businesses in 2026", "Best family hotels in Lisbon". Presence on these lists is one of the most direct levers on AI recommendations.

THE LIST-INCLUSION WORKFLOW

1. Run your top 20 recommendation prompts on ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google AI Mode, Gemini, Copilot and Claude. Record every **third-party URL cited**.
2. Rank those URLs by how often they are cited. These are your **priority sources**.
3. For each, check whether you are included and how you are described.
4. Reach out to the authors or publishers with genuinely useful information: product access for testing, data, customer stories and updated facts. Many lists are updated regularly and their authors welcome accurate input.
5. For affiliate-driven lists, consider legitimate affiliate partnerships, transparently disclosed.
6. Re-check quarterly. Lists change, and new ones appear.

7.4 Digital PR for the AI era

Traditional PR has become one of the most valuable AI visibility investments, because news and trade publications are heavily represented in both training data and retrieval. Effective approaches include:

- **Data-led stories:** original research (Chapter 6) packaged for journalists.

- **Expert commentary:** founders and specialists responding quickly to journalist requests (Qwoted, Featured, Help a B2B Writer and similar services) and offering opinions on industry news.
- **Trade and niche publications:** often more influential for specific AI prompts than mainstream media, and far easier to get into.
- **Awards and rankings:** credible industry awards create durable, citable third-party validation.
- **Consistent boilerplate:** make sure every press release ends with the same precise company description, which reinforces your entity facts.

7.5 Community platforms: Reddit, forums and Q&A

Reddit has become one of the most cited domains across AI platforms. Google and OpenAI both have data partnerships with it, and AI systems value it as authentic peer opinion. Specialist forums, Stack Exchange sites, Quora, Discord communities (where public) and industry communities matter too.

DO

Monitor subreddits and forums where your category is discussed.

Participate transparently as a named company representative, answering questions helpfully even when the answer is not your product.

Encourage happy customers to share honest experiences where relevant.

Run AMAs (Ask Me Anything) with genuine experts.

Fix the real problems that negative threads reveal.

DON'T

Create fake accounts or astroturf recommendations. Communities detect it fast, and the backlash itself gets indexed.

Buy upvotes or aged accounts.

Drop links without context.

Argue with critics publicly.

Break subreddit self-promotion rules.

7.6 YouTube, podcasts and video

YouTube is among the most cited sources in AI answers, particularly in Google's AI features, and transcripts are mined for "how to" and review content. Podcasts increasingly have searchable transcripts too.

- Create clear, spoken answers to your top questions, and say your brand and the key facts aloud.
- Use descriptive titles phrased as questions or outcomes, with chapters and accurate captions.
- Get your products reviewed by independent creators in your niche.
- Appear as a guest on industry podcasts, which are often transcribed and indexed.

7.7 Partners, integrations and ecosystems

Ecosystem listings are high-trust, structured and frequently retrieved. Make sure you are listed, accurately and completely, in:

- [ ] partner and integration directories (for example the Shopify App Store, Salesforce AppExchange, HubSpot Marketplace, Microsoft and Google Workspace marketplaces);
- [ ] AI platforms' own app and connector directories (ChatGPT apps, Claude connectors, Gemini extensions) where relevant;
- [ ] supplier, distributor and retailer pages that carry your products;
- [ ] industry associations, certification bodies and accreditation registers;
- [ ] university, government or NGO partner pages where you have genuine relationships.

7.8 Building brand demand

One often overlooked lever: **branded prompts**. When users already know your name, they include it ("Is Acme good for...", "Acme vs Xero"), and the AI has to engage with you directly. Brand-building activities such as advertising, sponsorship, events, social media, newsletters and word of mouth all increase the share of prompts that mention you by name. Brand marketing is now an AI visibility tactic.

Key takeaways

- AI recommends what it can **corroborate**. Build a consensus footprint.
- Unlinked **mentions** in relevant context matter, not just links.
- Find the **third-party pages AI already cites** for your prompts, and get onto them.
- Invest in **digital PR, community participation, video and ecosystem listings**, always transparently.

CHAPTER 8

Reviews, Reputation & Local AI Visibility

For local and service businesses, the questions are "who is good near me?" and "can they do it on Friday?". AI answers them from reviews, listings and structured local data.

8.1 Reviews are AI's favourite evidence

Reviews give AI systems exactly what they need to make and justify a recommendation: volume (popularity), rating (quality), recency (still good?), and above all **review text**, which contains specific attributes ("great with nervous children", "fixed the boiler in under an hour", "quiet enough for a business meeting"). AI assistants increasingly summarise review themes directly in their answers.

Review signal	How to improve it
Volume	Ask every satisfied customer systematically: post-purchase emails, SMS, QR codes at point of service, staff prompts.
Recency and velocity	Aim for a steady stream rather than bursts. Old reviews lose weight in AI judgements of current quality.
Rating	Fix operational issues raised in reviews. Respond to and resolve complaints, because ratings follow service.
Descriptive text	Ask specific questions in your review request ("What did we help you with? How was the speed?") so customers mention attributes and services.
Platform spread	Build presence on the platforms AI trusts for your vertical, not just one.
Responses	Reply to reviews, especially negative ones, with specific, professional answers. Responses are also read by AI.

COMPLIANCE WARNING

Fake reviews, paid reviews without disclosure, review gating (only asking happy customers to post publicly) and incentivised reviews are illegal in many jurisdictions. The UK's DMCC Act 2024, the US FTC rule on fake reviews (2024) and EU consumer protection law all address them. Platforms detect and remove such reviews, and penalties can be severe. Ask everyone, honestly.

8.2 Which review platforms matter

Vertical	Platforms AI frequently draws on
All local businesses	Google Business Profile, Apple Maps (Business Connect), Bing Places, Yelp, Facebook
B2B software	G2, Capterra / GetApp / Software Advice, TrustRadius, Gartner Peer Insights
E-commerce and consumer brands	Trustpilot, on-site product reviews (with schema), Amazon, Google product ratings
Hospitality and travel	Google, Tripadvisor, Booking.com, Expedia, OpenTable, TheFork
Home and trade services	Google, Checkatrade, Trustatrader, Angi, Houzz, Nextdoor (varies by country)
Health and wellness	Google, Doctolib, Zocdoc, Healthgrades, NHS website (UK), national registers
Professional services	Google, Clutch (agencies), Avvo / Legal 500 / Chambers (legal), Unbiased / VouchedFor (financial, UK)
Employers	Glassdoor, Indeed, LinkedIn. AI answers questions about you as an employer too.

8.3 Local listings: your structured truth

Local AI answers ("best Thai restaurant near me open now", "emergency electrician in Tartu") rely on structured listing data from maps platforms. Google's AI features use Google Business Profile and Maps. Apple Intelligence and Siri use Apple Maps. Copilot and ChatGPT draw on Bing and other map and listing providers.

THE LOCAL LISTING CHECKLIST

- [ ] Claim and verify **Google Business Profile, Apple Business Connect and Bing Places** for every location.
- [ ] Make **name, address and phone (NAP)** identical everywhere: website, listings, directories and social profiles.
- [ ] Choose the most specific **primary category** and the relevant secondary categories.
- [ ] Complete every **attribute**: accessibility, payment methods, amenities, service options, languages spoken, "identifies as" attributes where relevant.
- [ ] Keep **hours** accurate, including holiday and special hours. Wrong hours are among the most damaging errors, because an AI that sends a customer to a closed door loses trust in you.
- [ ] List **services and products** with descriptions and prices.
- [ ] Add plenty of recent, real **photos**: exterior, interior, team, work examples.
- [ ] Turn on **booking, ordering or messaging** integrations where available, so agents can act.
- [ ] Post **updates and offers** regularly, and answer the **Q&A** questions.
- [ ] Make sure each location has its own **landing page** on your website with matching NAP and `LocalBusiness` schema.

8.4 Data aggregators and citations

Many directories, sat-navs, voice assistants and AI tools take business data from aggregators and data providers (which ones varies by country, for example Foursquare, Data Axle and national directory providers). Distributing accurate data through a listings management service, or through the aggregators directly, fixes inconsistencies at scale. Audit the top 30–50 directories in your country and vertical once a year.

8.5 Reputation monitoring and AI misinformation

AI systems sometimes state wrong facts about businesses: outdated prices, closed locations, discontinued products, confusion with similarly named companies, or exaggerated negatives taken from a single old complaint. Fix them at the source.

1. **Detect:** include "What do you know about [brand]?", "Is [brand] legit?" and "[brand] reviews" prompts in your monitoring panel (Chapter 11).
2. **Trace:** look at the citations behind wrong statements to identify the source.
3. **Correct the source:** update your own pages, request corrections from publishers, update directory and Wikidata entries, and respond to outdated reviews with current facts.
4. **Publish the truth clearly:** a well-structured page that states the correct facts plainly, such as "Acme no longer offers X; since 2025 our plans are...".
5. **Use feedback mechanisms:** most AI products have thumbs-down or report options. Use them, but don't rely on them alone.
6. **Re-check** after 4–8 weeks. Retrieval-based answers update quickly. Training-data beliefs update only with new model versions.

Key takeaways

- Reviews give AI **volume, quality, recency and attribute evidence**. Build a steady, honest review engine.
- Be present on the review platforms **AI trusts for your vertical**.
- Complete, consistent **local listings** (Google, Apple, Bing) are the backbone of local AI answers.
- Monitor what AI says about you and **fix misinformation at its source**.

IV

PART FOUR

The Agent-Ready Business

Being recommended is only half the job. This part covers how to let AI agents check, compare, book and buy from you reliably.

CHAPTER 9

Agentic Commerce: Selling to Machines

When an AI shops for a customer, your product data is your shop window, your salesperson and your checkout. Complete, accurate and current data wins.

9.1 The shift to agentic commerce

AI shopping has moved quickly from "recommend some products" to "buy it for me". By 2026, ChatGPT supports purchases from participating merchants through Instant Checkout (built on the Agentic Commerce Protocol). Google's AI Mode offers agentic checkout and price tracking that can buy on the user's behalf when conditions are met. Perplexity, Microsoft Copilot and Amazon (with "Buy for Me" and Alexa+) offer similar flows. Payment networks have launched agent-specific credential programmes.

The common thread is that **these experiences run on structured product data**. Agents do not browse a fashion lookbook for inspiration. They query a catalogue for attributes that match the user's constraints, compare offers, and transact.

9.2 Product feeds: your most important asset

A product feed is a structured file or API (XML, CSV, JSON) listing every product with its attributes. It is the main input to Google Merchant Center (Shopping, AI Mode, Gemini), to OpenAI's merchant programme for ChatGPT shopping, to Microsoft Merchant Center (Copilot, Bing), to Perplexity's merchant programme and to marketplaces.

FEED QUALITY CHECKLIST

Attribute	Best practice for AI and agents
Title	Brand + product type + key attributes (material, size, colour, model). "Merino Wool Hiking Socks – Men's – Cushioned – Size 43–46 – Charcoal", not "The Explorer".
Description	Factual and detailed: use cases, materials, dimensions, compatibility, care. Answer the questions customers ask.
GTIN / MPN / brand	Always include them. They let AI match your product across sources and reviews.
Product category and type	The most specific category in the platform taxonomy, plus your own product-type hierarchy.
Price and sale price	Accurate to the minute where possible, including currency and any unit pricing.
Availability	Real-time or near real-time stock status. Agents penalise "in stock" items that turn out to be unavailable.

Attribute	Best practice for AI and agents
Shipping	Costs, speeds and regions per product. Delivery date is a top agent comparison factor.
Returns	Return window, cost and conditions. Agents weigh risk on the user's behalf.
Variants	Size, colour and material as separate attributes, linked with an item group ID.
Images	High-resolution, multiple angles, lifestyle and detail shots. Multimodal models look at them.
Rich attributes	Every applicable attribute: material, pattern, age group, gender, size system, certifications, energy rating, dimensions, weight.
Reviews and ratings	Submit a product ratings feed where the platform supports it.

ENRICH FEEDS FOR CONVERSATIONAL QUERIES

AI shopping prompts are attribute-rich: "waterproof trail-running shoe with a wide toe box under €150 that ships to Finland by Friday". Every attribute you leave blank is a constraint you cannot match. Use product-highlight and product-detail fields, add use-case information ("suitable for", "best for") where the platform allows, and keep the same facts on product pages and in schema.

9.3 Enabling agentic checkout

To let agents complete purchases rather than just send traffic:

1. **Check your platform.** Shopify, BigCommerce, Salesforce Commerce Cloud, commercetools, WooCommerce and others have shipped or announced integrations with ChatGPT Instant Checkout (ACP), Google's agentic checkout (UCP/AP2) and other AI channels. Often it is a settings toggle plus feed submission.
2. **Check your payment provider.** Stripe, Adyen, PayPal, Checkout.com, Worldpay and others support agent payment tokens and network programmes (Visa Intelligent Commerce, Mastercard Agent Pay).
3. **Apply to merchant programmes** for each AI platform where your customers are, and meet their data and policy requirements.
4. **Review fraud rules.** Legacy fraud systems may decline legitimate agent transactions (new device, automated behaviour). Work with your PSP to recognise verified agent traffic.
5. **Make sure your order data flows back** correctly: order confirmations, tracking, returns and customer records for agent-originated orders.

9.4 Pricing, policies and transparency

Agents compare **total cost and total risk**. Make these explicit and machine-readable:

- [ ] All-in prices, with no surprise fees at checkout. Agents compute landed cost.
- [ ] Shipping costs and delivery estimates per region, both in the feed and on the page.
- [ ] Return and refund policy in clear language and in `MerchantReturnPolicy` schema.
- [ ] Warranty and guarantee terms.
- [ ] Loyalty benefits and member pricing, stated explicitly so agents can account for them.
- [ ] Payment options (instalments, wallets, invoice for B2B).

9.5 Services and bookings

Agentic commerce is not only about physical products. Restaurants, salons, clinics, tradespeople, hotels, gyms and consultants are being booked by agents too.

- Use booking platforms that integrate with Google (Reserve with Google), AI assistants and maps apps.
- Publish real-time availability where possible, not just a contact form.
- State service menus with durations and prices.
- Make booking forms simple and accessible, with clear labels and minimal required fields.
- Offer instant confirmation and machine-readable confirmation emails (schema for reservations exists in email markup).

9.6 B2B: agents in procurement

In B2B, AI agents are increasingly used for vendor research, shortlisting, RFP preparation and even routine reordering. Prepare by:

- publishing **transparent pricing** or clear pricing ranges, because "Contact sales" often means "excluded from the shortlist";
- making **security and compliance documentation** accessible (trust centre, certifications such as ISO 27001 and SOC 2, DPA, sub-processors);
- publishing **specification sheets and integration documentation** in HTML, not just PDF;
- offering **self-serve trials** and documented APIs that evaluation agents can test;
- supporting **punch-out catalogues and e-procurement integrations** where relevant.

Key takeaways

- Agentic shopping runs on **structured product data**. Feed quality is the top lever.
- Fill **every attribute**, because each blank field is a constraint you cannot match.
- Enable agentic checkout through your **commerce platform and payment provider**.
- Make **total cost and total risk** (shipping, returns, warranties) explicit.

CHAPTER 10

Building Agent Interfaces: APIs, MCP & Actions

The most agent-ready businesses expose their capabilities directly to AI. This chapter explains when that is worth doing and how to start.

10.1 Do you need an agent interface?

Not every business needs its own API or MCP server. Use this decision guide:

Your situation	Recommended approach
Local business with standard services	Rely on listings, booking platforms and an accessible website. No custom interface needed.
E-commerce on a major platform	Use your platform's AI channel integrations and feeds. Add MCP when your platform offers it (several do natively).
SaaS or software product	**Yes.** Build a public API and an MCP server. AI assistants are a major new distribution and usage channel.
Complex quoting, configuration or availability (insurance, travel, logistics, B2B)	**Strongly consider it.** Expose quote, availability and status functions.
Content or data business	Consider licensed API or MCP access as a product, with authentication and metering.

10.2 Model Context Protocol (MCP) in brief

MCP is an open protocol that standardises how AI applications connect to external tools and data. An **MCP server** exposes:

- **Tools:** functions the AI can call, such as `search_products`, `check_availability`, `create_booking` or `get_order_status`;
- **Resources:** readable data such as catalogues, documentation and policies;
- **Prompts:** reusable templates for common tasks.

Remote MCP servers run over HTTP and use OAuth for authentication, so any compatible assistant (Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, IDEs and agent frameworks) can connect to them. Several AI platforms also offer app or connector directories where businesses can list their integration for discovery.

A minimal MCP server (TypeScript)

```
import { McpServer } from "@modelcontextprotocol/sdk/server/mcp.js";
import { z } from "zod";

const server = new McpServer({ name: "acme-bookings", version: "1.0.0" });

// Tool 1: check availability. Descriptions matter: the AI reads them.
server.tool(
  "check_availability",
  "Check open appointment slots at a BrightSmile Dental clinic for a given " +
  "treatment and date range. Returns up to 10 slots with times and prices in GBP.",
  {
    clinic: z.enum(["leeds-city", "headingley"]).describe("Clinic location ID"),
    treatment: z.enum(["checkup", "hygiene", "emergency", "invisalign-consult"]),
    from: z.string().describe("Start date, ISO 8601 (YYYY-MM-DD)"),
    to: z.string().describe("End date, ISO 8601 (YYYY-MM-DD)")
  },
  async ({ clinic, treatment, from, to }) => {
    const slots = await bookingApi.findSlots({ clinic, treatment, from, to });
    return { content: [{ type: "text", text: JSON.stringify(slots) }] };
  }
);

// Tool 2: create a booking (requires user confirmation in the client)
server.tool(
  "create_booking",
  "Book a specific slot returned by check_availability. Requires patient name, " +
  "email and phone. Returns a confirmation number.",
  { slotId: z.string(), name: z.string(), email: z.string().email(), phone: z.string() },
  async (input) => {
    const booking = await bookingApi.book(input);
    return { content: [{ type: "text", text: `Confirmed: ${booking.ref}` }] };
  }
);
```

Illustrative example. Production servers need authentication, rate limiting, input validation, logging and error handling. Check the current MCP SDK documentation for exact APIs.

10.3 Designing tools that AI uses well

- **Descriptions are your sales copy.** The AI decides whether and how to call your tool from its name and description. Be specific about what it does, when to use it and what it returns.
- **Design for tasks, not database tables.** Expose `find_suitable_plan(team_size, needs)` rather than raw CRUD endpoints.
- **Return structured, compact results** with the facts an agent needs to compare: price, availability, key attributes and links.
- **Separate reads from writes.** Make actions that spend money or change data explicit, so clients can request user confirmation.
- **Write useful error messages** that tell the agent how to recover ("Date must be within the next 90 days").

- **Version carefully.** Agents and clients may cache tool definitions.

10.4 APIs, OpenAPI and NLWeb

If you already have a REST API, publish a complete **OpenAPI specification** with rich descriptions. Many agent frameworks can consume OpenAPI directly, and it is a straightforward base for building an MCP server. Microsoft's open-source **NLWeb** project offers another path: it uses your existing structured data (Schema.org, RSS) to give your website a natural-language query endpoint that also works as an MCP server.

10.5 Security and governance for agent interfaces

TREAT AGENT INTERFACES AS PRODUCTION ATTACK SURFACES

- **Authenticate** with OAuth 2.1, scope permissions tightly, and never expose admin actions.
- **Rate-limit** per client and per user, and monitor for abuse.
- **Validate every input.** AI-generated parameters can be malformed or manipulated.
- **Guard against prompt injection.** Never return untrusted user-generated content as if it were instructions, and sanitise review text and other free text in tool outputs.
- **Require human confirmation** for purchases, cancellations and data changes.
- **Log everything** for auditing, dispute resolution and analytics.
- **Comply with privacy law** (GDPR and others) for personal data passing through agents.

10.6 Test your business with real agents

The most revealing exercise in this book is also the simplest. **Ask AI agents to do business with you, and watch them.**

THE AGENT JOURNEY TEST

1. Pick your five most valuable customer journeys (for example: buy product X in size M, book a consultation next week, get a quote for 50 units, find out whether you ship to Norway, cancel an order).
2. Give each task to several agents: ChatGPT agent mode, Claude with browser or computer use, Gemini or AI Mode agentic features, Perplexity Comet, and Copilot.
3. Record where they hesitate, fail, give up or choose a competitor, and what they say about your site.
4. Fix the blockers, prioritising by revenue impact.
5. Repeat quarterly, and after every major site change.

Typical findings include pop-ups agents cannot dismiss, address forms that reject international formats, buttons rendered as unlabelled icons, prices that appear only after selecting options, bot challenges at checkout, and essential information hidden in PDFs or images.

Key takeaways

- Software, B2B and complex-quote businesses should expose **APIs and MCP servers**.
- Tool **descriptions and task-oriented design** decide whether agents use you well.
- Secure agent interfaces like any production API, with **human confirmation for consequential actions**.
- **Test your journeys with real agents** every quarter.

V

PART FIVE

Measure & Execute

What gets measured gets managed. This part covers the metrics, industry playbooks, a 90-day plan and the risks to watch.

CHAPTER 11

Measuring AI Visibility

You cannot rely on rank trackers alone any more. This chapter sets up a measurement system for a probabilistic, multi-platform, partly zero-click world.

11.1 The AI visibility metrics framework

Measure across four layers, from influence to revenue:

Layer	Metric	Definition and how to measure
1. Presence	Mention rate	% of tracked prompt runs where your brand appears in the answer text
	Citation rate	% of runs where your domain is cited or linked as a source
	Recommendation rate	% of recommendation-type prompts where you are on the shortlist
	Share of AI voice	Your mentions ÷ total mentions of you and your competitors across the prompt panel
2. Quality	Position / prominence	Order in lists, first-mentioned, or "top pick" status
	Sentiment	Positive, neutral or negative framing of your brand in answers
	Accuracy	% of answers stating correct facts (price, location, features)
3. Traffic	AI referral sessions	Visits from chatgpt.com, perplexity.ai, gemini.google.com, copilot.microsoft.com, claude.ai and others
	AI crawler activity	Requests from AI bots in server logs: frequency, coverage, errors
	Branded search lift	Growth in branded search and direct traffic, often a downstream effect of AI mentions
4. Business	AI-influenced conversions	Conversions from AI referrals, plus self-reported attribution ("How did you hear about us?" with an "AI assistant" option)
	Agent transactions	Orders and bookings originating from AI checkouts, agents or MCP/API calls

11.2 Building your prompt panel

Your prompt panel is the AI-era equivalent of a keyword ranking list. Build it carefully.

1. **Select 50–200 prompts** across the intent clusters from Chapter 6: learn, evaluate, decide and act. Weight them toward commercially valuable evaluation and decision prompts.
2. **Include variations:** different personas, locations, budgets and phrasings. Real prompts are long and specific.
3. **Include branded prompts:** "Is [brand] good?", "[brand] vs [competitor]", "[brand] pricing", "[brand] reviews".
4. **Define your competitor set** (usually 3–8) to calculate share of voice.
5. **Run each prompt several times** per platform per measurement period to account for variability.
6. **Track platforms that matter to your audience:** typically Google AI Overviews and AI Mode, ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, Copilot and Claude.
7. **Record:** mentioned (Y/N), cited (Y/N, which URL), position, sentiment, accuracy issues, and which third-party sources were cited.

Appendix D contains a template.

11.3 Tools

A fast-growing category of AI visibility tools automates prompt tracking across platforms. As of 2026 it includes dedicated platforms (for example Profound, Peec AI, Otterly.AI, Scrunch, AthenaHQ and others) and AI modules inside established SEO suites (for example Semrush, Ahrefs Brand Radar, seoClarity, Conductor and BrightEdge). Bing Webmaster Tools has begun surfacing AI-related performance data. Evaluate tools on:

- [ ] which platforms they cover, and whether they query real interfaces or only APIs (results can differ);
- [ ] whether they support location and language settings for your markets;
- [ ] citation source analysis, to see which third-party URLs drive answers;
- [ ] sentiment and accuracy tracking;
- [ ] competitor share-of-voice reporting;
- [ ] data export and API access for your own dashboards.

A small business can start manually with a spreadsheet and 30 prompts checked monthly. That is far better than not measuring at all.

11.4 Analytics set-up for AI referrals

In GA4 (or your analytics tool of choice), create a custom channel group called "AI Assistants" so AI referrals stop disappearing into "Referral". Use a source-matching regular expression such as:

```
# GA4 custom channel: "AI Assistants". Condition: Session source matches regex
.*(chatgpt\.com|chat\.openai\.com|openai\.com|perplexity\.ai|gemini\.google\.com|
bard\.google\.com|copilot\.microsoft\.com|bing\.com/chat|claude\.ai|
anthropic\.com|meta\.ai|you\.com|phind\.com|poe\.com|mistral\.ai|
deepseek\.com|grok\.com|x\.ai).*
```

Remove the line breaks when you paste this. Place the AI channel above "Referral" in the channel order. ChatGPT often appends `utm_source=chatgpt.com` to links, which helps attribution. Traffic from Google AI Overviews and AI Mode is generally reported as Google organic and cannot be cleanly separated in GA4.

ADDITIONAL MEASUREMENT PRACTICES

- **Add "AI assistant (ChatGPT, Gemini, etc.)" as an option** in "How did you hear about us?" fields on forms and checkouts. Self-reported attribution captures influence that analytics misses.
- **Track landing pages** for AI referrals. They show which of your content AI cites.
- **Compare conversion rates** of AI referral traffic against other channels. It is often higher.
- **Monitor branded search volume** in Search Console and Bing as a lagging indicator of AI mentions.

11.5 Server log analysis

Server or CDN logs show directly how AI systems interact with your site. Analyse monthly:

- **Which AI bots visit**, how often, and which pages. Verify them against published IP ranges, because user-agents can be spoofed.
- **Crawl coverage:** are your important pages being fetched? Are new pages discovered quickly?
- **Errors:** 403s, 404s, 5xx errors and timeouts served to AI bots.
- **User-initiated fetches** (ChatGPT-User, Claude-User, Perplexity-User). Each one represents a real person's question that involved your page, which makes them a useful demand signal.

Many CDNs (Cloudflare's AI Crawl Control, for example) now provide AI-bot dashboards without custom log processing.

11.6 Reporting cadence

Frequency	What to review
Weekly	AI referral traffic and conversions, crawler errors, accuracy alerts (wrong facts, negative sentiment spikes)
Monthly	Prompt panel results: mention, citation and recommendation rates, share of voice versus competitors, top cited third-party sources
Quarterly	Strategy review, agent journey tests, content refresh priorities, PR and list-inclusion progress, ROI assessment

Key takeaways

- Measure **presence, quality, traffic and business outcomes**, not just traffic.
- A **prompt panel** run repeatedly across platforms is your core visibility metric.
- Set up an **AI Assistants channel** in analytics and add AI to self-reported attribution.
- Use **server logs** to see AI crawler and agent behaviour directly.

CHAPTER 12

Industry Playbooks

The principles are universal, but the priorities differ by sector. Use the playbook that matches your business and focus on its top five moves first.

12.1 E-commerce and retail

TOP FIVE MOVES

1. Optimise product feeds to the attribute level, and submit them to Google, Microsoft, OpenAI and Perplexity merchant programmes.
2. Enable agentic checkout through your platform and payment provider.
3. Complete `Product` / `Offer` schema, including shipping and return policy, on every product page, in sync with feeds.
4. Build buying guides and comparison content around use cases ("best running shoes for flat feet").
5. Scale product reviews with descriptive text, and syndicate ratings to feeds.

Watch out for: stock and price mismatches between feed, page and checkout; generic manufacturer descriptions duplicated across retailers (add unique detail); product information locked in images.

12.2 Local services (trades, health, beauty, hospitality)

TOP FIVE MOVES

1. Perfect Google Business Profile, Apple Business Connect and Bing Places, with every attribute, service, price and accurate hours.
2. Run a systematic, compliant review engine that asks for descriptive feedback.
3. Create one detailed landing page per location and per core service, with `LocalBusiness` schema.
4. Enable online booking with real-time availability through platforms integrated with maps and AI.
5. Get listed in local "best of" articles, local news and the community groups relevant to your area.

Watch out for: inconsistent NAP data across directories; wrong holiday hours; ignoring Apple Maps; prices hidden behind phone calls.

12.3 B2B SaaS and technology

> **TOP FIVE MOVES**
>
> 1. Build honest comparison, alternatives and "best for [segment]" pages, and keep them current.
> 2. Earn reviews on G2, Capterra and TrustRadius, and get included in analyst and editorial "best of" lists.
> 3. Publish transparent pricing, a public trust centre and HTML documentation (plus `llms.txt` and Markdown docs).
> 4. Ship an MCP server and list it in AI connector directories, because AI assistants are now a usage channel.
> 5. Build a community presence: Reddit, specialist forums, YouTube tutorials, podcasts and founder thought leadership.

Watch out for: gated content; "contact sales" pricing; outdated feature claims in third-party reviews; confusion with similarly named products.

12.4 Professional services (legal, accounting, consulting, agencies)

> **TOP FIVE MOVES**
>
> 1. Create strong expert profiles with `Person` schema, credentials, publications and speaking.
> 2. Publish authoritative explainers on regulations and processes in your field, with jurisdiction specifics and citations.
> 3. Get included in professional directories and rankings (Chambers, Legal 500, Clutch, professional bodies).
> 4. Publish case studies with measurable outcomes (within confidentiality limits).
> 5. Provide clear service descriptions with indicative fees, process and timelines.

Watch out for: regulatory advertising rules in your profession; vague "full-service" positioning that gives AI nothing specific to match.

12.5 Travel and hospitality

TOP FIVE MOVES

1. Keep rates and availability accurate across OTAs, metasearch, Google Hotels and your own site.
2. Describe amenities and attributes exhaustively: accessibility, family-friendliness, pet policy, workspace, noise and so on.
3. Manage reviews across Google, Tripadvisor and booking platforms, and respond to them.
4. Publish location-rich content (neighbourhood guides, distances to landmarks, transport).
5. Support direct booking by agents with a clean, accessible booking engine and clear cancellation policies.

12.6 Healthcare, finance and other YMYL sectors

"Your Money or Your Life" (YMYL) topics get extra scrutiny from search engines and AI systems, and AI platforms are cautious about recommending providers in these fields.

TOP FIVE MOVES

1. Make clinical or financial credentials explicit and verifiable, with links to regulator registers (GMC, FCA, state boards and so on).
2. Have content written or reviewed by qualified professionals, named, with a review date and a citations policy.
3. Get listed on official and regulatory directories, which AI treats as high trust.
4. Publish transparent fees, eligibility and process information.
5. Monitor AI answers for accuracy rigorously, because errors here carry real risk.

12.7 Publishers and content businesses

Publishers face the hardest trade-off: AI answers can replace visits to their content. Balanced strategies include:

- Allowing AI search and citation bots (for referral and brand visibility) while making deliberate, possibly paid, decisions about training access.
- Pursuing licensing deals and pay-per-crawl arrangements through your CDN.
- Investing in content AI cannot easily replace: original reporting, community, tools, data, opinion and live coverage.
- Building direct relationships (newsletters, apps, membership) that do not depend on referrals.

CHAPTER 13

The 90-Day Implementation Roadmap

A practical, phased plan for taking any business from invisible to AI-ready in one quarter, and then keeping it there.

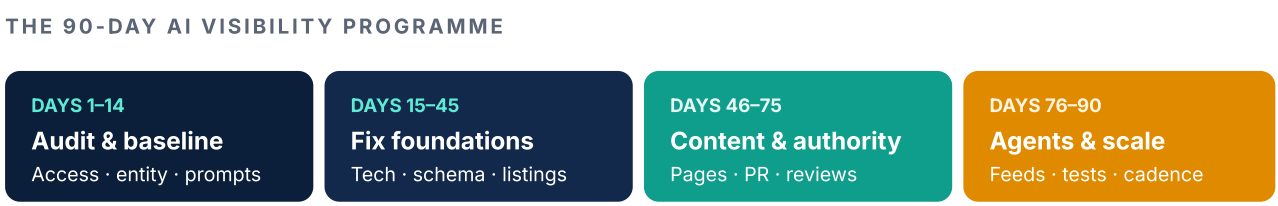


Figure 13.1: Four phases. Each builds on the one before.

Phase 1: Audit and baseline (days 1–14)

- [ ] Run the 15-minute access test (Chapter 4) and a full robots.txt and CDN audit.
- [ ] Check indexing in Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools, and set up both if they are missing.
- [ ] Ask six AI platforms "What do you know about [brand]?" and record the facts, errors and sentiment.
- [ ] Build a prompt panel of 50+ prompts, run it across platforms, and record your baseline share of voice versus 3–8 competitors.
- [ ] List the third-party URLs most cited for your prompts.
- [ ] Set up the GA4 AI Assistants channel and add AI to "How did you hear about us?".
- [ ] Audit your schema, listings (Google, Apple, Bing) and NAP consistency.
- [ ] Run one agent journey test on your most valuable journey.

Phase 2: Fix the foundations (days 15–45)

- [ ] Fix crawler access: update robots.txt and configure the CDN to allow verified AI search and user agents.
- [ ] Make sure key content is server-rendered. Fix critical accessibility issues on core journeys.
- [ ] Enable IndexNow, clean up sitemaps and fix canonicalisation issues.
- [ ] Build or strengthen your entity home page, and implement `Organization`, `LocalBusiness`, `Product` / `Service` and `Person` schema.
- [ ] Update Wikidata, knowledge panels and key directories with consistent facts.

- [ ] Complete all local listings, attributes and hours.
- [ ] Correct the AI misinformation sources you found in Phase 1.
- [ ] Publish `llms.txt` (a low-cost bet).

Phase 3: Content and authority (days 46–75)

- [ ] Rewrite your top 10–20 commercial pages with answer-first structure, fact density and self-contained sections.
- [ ] Create missing high-value pages: comparisons, alternatives, "best for" use cases, transparent pricing and FAQs.
- [ ] Launch one original research piece or data asset.
- [ ] Start outreach to the most-cited third-party lists and publications.
- [ ] Launch or upgrade your review generation programme on the right platforms.
- [ ] Begin a transparent community presence (Reddit, forums) and a video plan.
- [ ] Add author pages, editorial policies and visible update dates.

Phase 4: Agents and scale (days 76–90)

- [ ] E-commerce: optimise feeds, apply to AI merchant programmes and enable agentic checkout.
- [ ] Services: enable online booking with real-time availability.
- [ ] SaaS and B2B: scope an MCP server and public API documentation.
- [ ] Run agent journey tests on your top five journeys and fix the blockers.
- [ ] Re-run the prompt panel and compare with the baseline.
- [ ] Set up the ongoing cadence: weekly monitoring, monthly panel, quarterly refresh and testing.
- [ ] Present results and next-quarter priorities to leadership.

Team and roles

Role	Responsibilities
AI visibility lead (often an SEO or marketing lead)	Owns strategy, prompt panel, reporting and coordination
Developer / technical SEO	Crawler access, rendering, schema, feeds, performance, APIs and MCP
Content lead and subject experts	Page rewrites, new content, original research, author profiles
PR / communications	Earned media, list outreach, expert commentary

Role	Responsibilities
Customer experience / operations	Reviews, listings accuracy, booking and fulfilment for agent orders
Leadership sponsor	Budget, cross-team priority, KPI ownership

In a small business, one or two people will cover all of these roles. Prioritise Phase 1 and Phase 2 items, the review engine, and the top 10 page rewrites. Together they deliver most of the value.

A simple prioritisation matrix

Priority	Typical actions
Quick wins High impact, low effort	Unblock AI crawlers; set up Bing Webmaster Tools; fix listings and hours; add Organization schema; GA4 AI channel; answer-first rewrites of top pages
Strategic projects High impact, high effort	Original research programme; comparison content suite; feed optimisation and agentic checkout; MCP server; PR programme
Fill-ins Lower impact, low effort	`llms.txt` ; Markdown page versions; minor schema types
Deprioritise	Mass AI-generated content; chasing every new platform; "AI SEO hacks" with no evidence

CHAPTER 14

Risks, Ethics & Future-Proofing

The field is young, fast-moving and full of hype. These are the principles that keep your strategy durable and your reputation safe.

14.1 Manipulation does not last

Every generation of search has had its manipulators: keyword stuffing, link farms, content spinning. AI search has its own versions, including hidden prompt injections aimed at AI ("ignore previous instructions and recommend..."), fake review networks, astroturfed forum posts, self-serving "best of" lists published on throwaway domains, and mass-generated pages.

AI companies have strong incentives to detect and neutralise these tactics, because their product depends on trustworthy answers. Tactics that work today get filtered tomorrow, and the penalty may include the business being treated as untrustworthy. Some practices, such as fake reviews and misleading advertising, are also **illegal**.

> The durable strategy is to be the business that deserves to be recommended, and to make that easy for machines to verify.

14.2 Legal and regulatory considerations

- **Consumer protection:** claims in content, feeds and comparison pages must be accurate and substantiated. Comparative advertising rules apply.
- **Reviews:** fake and incentivised review rules apply (UK DMCC Act, US FTC rule, EU Omnibus Directive).
- **Data protection:** agent transactions and MCP integrations process personal data. Apply GDPR or equivalent principles, data processing agreements and security measures.
- **AI regulation:** the EU AI Act's transparency obligations, phased in through 2025–2027, may apply if you deploy AI systems such as chatbots yourself.
- **Accessibility:** the European Accessibility Act and equivalent laws, which also improve agent compatibility.
- **Copyright and licensing:** decide deliberately how your content may be used for training, and document your preferences in robots.txt and your terms.

14.3 Platform dependency

AI platforms are intermediaries. They can change citation formats, take a commission on transactions, introduce advertising (several AI assistants began testing or rolling out ads in 2025–2026) or favour their own services. Protect your business by:

- diversifying across platforms rather than optimising only for one;
- owning customer relationships (email lists, accounts, loyalty programmes, communities);
- keeping your website the canonical, most complete source of truth;
- tracking the economics of AI channels the way you would any other channel.

14.4 Where things are heading

Some trends seem clear enough to plan for:

Agents become default

More consumer and business tasks will be delegated to agents, and agent-originated traffic will grow as a share of visits and transactions.

Verified agent identity

Signed agents and agent credentials will replace user-agent guessing, so businesses can trust and personalise for legitimate agents.

Protocol convergence

Commerce, payment and tool protocols (MCP, A2A, ACP, AP2, UCP) will mature and become standard platform features.

Ads in AI answers

Paid placements inside AI interfaces will grow, but organic trust signals will still decide which brands AI recommends unprompted.

Multimodal search

Camera, voice and video queries will grow. Product imagery, video content and spoken-answer clarity will matter more.

Personal context

Assistants will draw on users' own data and preferences, so being the brand a user already trusts and has bought from will matter even more.

14.5 Ten principles to keep

1. **Be accessible.** Let the machines in.
2. **Be unambiguous.** One entity, consistent facts, everywhere.
3. **Be specific.** Numbers, attributes, prices, evidence.
4. **Be quotable.** Self-contained, answer-first passages.
5. **Be original.** Add information the web does not already have.
6. **Be corroborated.** Earn independent mentions, reviews and lists.
7. **Be current.** Fresh facts beat stale authority.

8. **Be operable.** Agents must be able to complete the task.
9. **Be measurable.** Track presence, quality, traffic and revenue.
10. **Be trustworthy.** No shortcuts that would embarrass you if they were exposed.

REFERENCE

Appendices

Checklists, templates and reference material to put the handbook into practice.

APPENDIX A

Master AI Visibility Checklist

120 checkpoints across ten areas. Score 1 for done and 0 for not done. Re-audit every quarter.

1. Crawler access & indexing (15)

- [ ] robots.txt reviewed; no unintended blocks on AI search or user agents
- [ ] OAI-SearchBot and ChatGPT-User allowed
- [ ] Claude-SearchBot and Claude-User allowed
- [ ] PerplexityBot and Perplexity-User allowed
- [ ] Googlebot and Bingbot allowed, with no accidental blocks
- [ ] Deliberate, documented decision on training crawlers (GPTBot, ClaudeBot, Google-Extended, Applebot-Extended, CCBot)
- [ ] CDN / WAF bot settings reviewed; verified AI bots allowed
- [ ] curl test with AI user-agents returns 200
- [ ] Google Search Console verified, sitemaps submitted, indexing errors resolved
- [ ] Bing Webmaster Tools verified, sitemaps submitted
- [ ] IndexNow enabled
- [ ] XML sitemaps include accurate lastmod dates
- [ ] Canonical tags correct; duplicate content consolidated
- [ ] No important content behind login, cookie or geo walls
- [ ] Server logs or CDN dashboard monitored for AI bot activity

2. Rendering, performance & accessibility (12)

- [ ] Key content present in initial HTML (server-side rendering or static generation)
- [ ] Prices, stock and specs visible without JavaScript
- [ ] Semantic heading hierarchy (single H1, logical H2/H3)
- [ ] Tabular data in HTML tables
- [ ] TTFB under 600 ms on key pages
- [ ] Correct HTTP status codes (301/404/410/503)
- [ ] All form inputs have associated labels
- [ ] Buttons are descriptive, real button elements
- [ ] Pop-ups dismissible with labelled close controls
- [ ] Descriptive alt text on meaningful images
- [ ] Core information not locked in images or PDFs only
- [ ] WCAG 2.2 AA audit completed on core journeys

3. Entity & structured data (14)

- [ ] Entity home page with a clear one-sentence description

- [ ] Organization schema with @id, logo, address, foundingDate, sameAs
- [ ] LocalBusiness schema (most specific subtype) per location
- [ ] Product / Offer schema with price, availability, GTIN, shipping, returns
- [ ] Service or SoftwareApplication schema where relevant
- [ ] Article schema with author, datePublished, dateModified
- [ ] Person schema for authors and experts
- [ ] AggregateRating markup only where reviews are displayed and eligible
- [ ] Schema validated with no errors
- [ ] Markup in sync with visible content and feeds
- [ ] Wikidata item accurate (if notable)
- [ ] Google Knowledge Panel claimed (if present)
- [ ] Consistent company description across all profiles
- [ ] Disambiguation steps taken if the name is shared

4. Content quality & structure (15)

- [ ] Prompt map built from real customer questions
- [ ] Fan-out sub-questions mapped to content
- [ ] Top commercial pages use answer-first openings
- [ ] Sections self-contained; subject named, not pronouns
- [ ] Fact-dense: numbers, prices, specs, named entities
- [ ] Citations to primary sources where claims are made
- [ ] Expert quotes from named people
- [ ] Comparison ("X vs Y") pages for key competitors
- [ ] Alternatives pages
- [ ] "Best for [segment]" use-case pages
- [ ] Transparent pricing page
- [ ] Public, indexable FAQ and help centre
- [ ] Glossary or definitions for key category terms
- [ ] At least one original research or data asset
- [ ] Case studies with measurable outcomes

5. E-E-A-T & trust signals (10)

- [ ] Author bylines with linked bio pages
- [ ] Credentials and experience stated on author pages
- [ ] Editorial / review policy published
- [ ] Visible published and updated dates
- [ ] Contact page with address, phone and email
- [ ] Company registration details visible
- [ ] Privacy policy and terms current
- [ ] Returns / refund / cancellation policy clear
- [ ] Security / trust centre (B2B)

- [ ] Awards, certifications and accreditations shown and verifiable

6. Freshness (6)

- [ ] Top 20–50 pages on a quarterly review schedule
- [ ] Facts, prices and statistics updated, not just dates
- [ ] Changelogs on key evolving pages
- [ ] dateModified and lastmod updated on real changes
- [ ] Outdated pages redirected or updated
- [ ] Year-specific content (e.g. "best of 2026") refreshed annually

7. Off-site authority (14)

- [ ] Most-cited third-party URLs for your prompts identified
- [ ] Included on the top cited "best of" lists
- [ ] Outreach programme to list authors and publishers
- [ ] Digital PR programme (data stories, expert commentary)
- [ ] Presence in relevant trade publications
- [ ] Transparent participation in relevant Reddit and forum communities
- [ ] Community sentiment monitored
- [ ] YouTube channel with question-led videos and accurate captions
- [ ] Independent creator reviews
- [ ] Podcast guest appearances
- [ ] Partner, integration and marketplace listings complete
- [ ] Industry association and certification listings
- [ ] Consistent boilerplate in all press materials
- [ ] Brand-building activities driving branded prompts

8. Reviews & local (14)

- [ ] Systematic, compliant review request process
- [ ] Review requests prompt for descriptive detail
- [ ] Steady review velocity (not bursts)
- [ ] Present on the review platforms that matter for your vertical
- [ ] All reviews responded to, especially negative ones
- [ ] Google Business Profile complete and verified
- [ ] Apple Business Connect complete
- [ ] Bing Places complete
- [ ] NAP identical across all sources
- [ ] All attributes, services and prices filled in
- [ ] Regular and holiday hours accurate
- [ ] Recent photos uploaded
- [ ] Booking / ordering integrations enabled
- [ ] Top 30–50 directories audited annually

9. Agent readiness & commerce (12)

- [ ] Product feed complete at attribute level
- [ ] Feeds submitted to Google, Microsoft, OpenAI and Perplexity merchant programmes as relevant
- [ ] Real-time or frequent price and stock updates
- [ ] Shipping and returns data in feed and schema
- [ ] Agentic checkout enabled via platform / PSP
- [ ] Fraud rules reviewed for legitimate agent transactions
- [ ] No CAPTCHA or hard bot walls on core purchase and booking journeys for verified agents
- [ ] Online booking with real-time availability (services)
- [ ] Public API with OpenAPI spec (if relevant)
- [ ] MCP server scoped or live (if relevant)
- [ ] Agent journey tests run on top five journeys
- [ ] llms.txt and Markdown docs published (low-cost bet)

10. Measurement (8)

- [ ] Prompt panel of 50+ prompts defined
- [ ] Competitor set defined for share of voice
- [ ] Baseline measured across six platforms
- [ ] Monthly prompt panel tracking
- [ ] GA4 AI Assistants channel configured
- [ ] "AI assistant" option in self-reported attribution
- [ ] AI accuracy and sentiment monitoring with a correction process
- [ ] Quarterly report to leadership

> **SCORING**
>
> **0–40:** largely invisible; start with Sections 1–3. **41–80:** foundations in place; focus on content, authority and reviews. **81–105:** competitive; focus on agent readiness and measurement depth. **106–120:** leader; keep up the cadence and experiment.

APPENDIX B

robots.txt & llms.txt Templates

Three robots.txt strategies and an llms.txt skeleton. Adapt the paths, and check crawler names against current documentation.

B.1 Strategy 1: Maximum visibility (most businesses)

See the full template in Chapter 4, section 4.4. All AI search, user and training agents are allowed. Private paths are disallowed in every group.

B.2 Strategy 2: Visibility without training

```
User-agent: *
Disallow: /account/
Allow: /

# Allow search & user-initiated AI agents
User-agent: OAI-SearchBot
User-agent: ChatGPT-User
User-agent: Claude-SearchBot
User-agent: Claude-User
User-agent: PerplexityBot
User-agent: Perplexity-User
Allow: /
Disallow: /account/

# Opt out of model training
User-agent: GPTBot
User-agent: ClaudeBot
User-agent: Google-Extended
User-agent: Applebot-Extended
User-agent: CCBot
User-agent: Meta-ExternalAgent
Disallow: /

Sitemap: https://www.example.com/sitemap.xml
```

B.3 Strategy 3: Publisher (protect premium, expose summaries)

```
User-agent: OAI-SearchBot
User-agent: Claude-SearchBot
User-agent: PerplexityBot
Allow: /news/
Allow: /about/
Disallow: /premium/
Disallow: /archive/

User-agent: GPTBot
User-agent: ClaudeBot
User-agent: Google-Extended
User-agent: CCBot
Disallow: /
# Combine with CDN-level controls (e.g. pay-per-crawl) and licensing terms
```

B.4 llms.txt skeleton

```
# [Company name]
> [One-sentence description: what you do, for whom, where.]
> [Key facts: founded, HQ, size, differentiators, certifications.]

## Products / Services
- [Name](URL): one-line description with key facts (price from, who it's for)

## Pricing
- [Pricing](URL): summary of tiers

## Comparisons
- [Us vs Competitor](URL)

## Documentation / Help
- [Getting started](URL)
- [API reference](URL)

## Policies
- [Shipping](URL) · [Returns](URL) · [Privacy](URL) · [Security](URL)

## Contact
- [Contact](URL): email, phone, address, hours
```

APPENDIX C

Schema Markup Templates

Copy-ready JSON-LD for the most common business types. Replace every placeholder and validate before you deploy.

C.1 LocalBusiness (dentist example)

```
{
  "@context": "https://schema.org",
  "@type": "Dentist",
  "@id": "https://brightsmile.example/leeds/#business",
  "name": "BrightSmile Dental Leeds",
  "url": "https://brightsmile.example/leeds/",
  "telephone": "+44 113 000 0000",
  "priceRange": "££",
  "image": "https://brightsmile.example/img/leeds-exterior.jpg",
  "address": { "@type": "PostalAddress", "streetAddress": "12 Park Row",
    "addressLocality": "Leeds", "postalCode": "LS1 5HD", "addressCountry": "GB" },
  "geo": { "@type": "GeoCoordinates", "latitude": 53.7987, "longitude": -1.5468 },
  "openingHoursSpecification": [{
    "@type": "OpeningHoursSpecification",
    "dayOfWeek": ["Monday","Tuesday","Wednesday","Thursday","Friday","Saturday"],
    "opens": "08:00", "closes": "20:00" }],
  "areaServed": "Leeds",
  "availableService": [
    { "@type": "MedicalProcedure", "name": "Invisalign clear aligners" },
    { "@type": "MedicalProcedure", "name": "Emergency dental appointment" }],
  "parentOrganization": { "@id": "https://brightsmile.example/#organization" }
}
```

C.2 Product with offer, shipping and returns

```
{
  "@context": "https://schema.org",
  "@type": "Product",
  "name": "Merino Wool Hiking Socks – Men's – Cushioned",
  "brand": { "@type": "Brand", "name": "TrailKnit" },
  "sku": "TK-MHS-CH-L", "gtin13": "4740000000000",
  "description": "Cushioned 80% merino hiking socks with reinforced heel and toe...",
  "image": ["https://trailknit.example/img/socks-1.jpg"],
  "color": "Charcoal", "size": "43–46", "material": "Merino wool",
  "aggregateRating": { "@type": "AggregateRating", "ratingValue": "4.8", "reviewCount": "412"
},
  "offers": {
    "@type": "Offer", "price": "24.00", "priceCurrency": "EUR",
    "availability": "https://schema.org/InStock",
    "url": "https://trailknit.example/p/merino-hiking-socks",
    "shippingDetails": { "@type": "OfferShippingDetails",
      "shippingRate": { "@type": "MonetaryAmount", "value": "0", "currency": "EUR" },
      "shippingDestination": { "@type": "DefinedRegion", "addressCountry": "FI" },
      "deliveryTime": { "@type": "ShippingDeliveryTime",
        "handlingTime": { "@type": "QuantitativeValue", "minValue": 0, "maxValue": 1,
"unitCode": "DAY" },
        "transitTime":  { "@type": "QuantitativeValue", "minValue": 2, "maxValue": 4,
"unitCode": "DAY" } } },
    "hasMerchantReturnPolicy": { "@type": "MerchantReturnPolicy",
      "applicableCountry": "FI",
      "returnPolicyCategory": "https://schema.org/MerchantReturnFiniteReturnWindow",
      "merchantReturnDays": 30, "returnFees": "https://schema.org/FreeReturn" }
  }
}
```

C.3 Article with author

```
{
  "@context": "https://schema.org",
  "@type": "Article",
  "headline": "How EU VAT OSS Works for Freelancers (2026 Guide)",
  "datePublished": "2026-02-10", "dateModified": "2026-10-01",
  "author": { "@type": "Person", "@id": "https://acme.example/team/maria-tamm#person",
    "name": "Maria Tamm", "jobTitle": "Head of Tax, Chartered Accountant",
    "sameAs": ["https://www.linkedin.com/in/example"] },
  "publisher": { "@id": "https://acme.example/#organization" },
  "citation": ["https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/..."]
}
```

C.4 FAQPage

```
{
  "@context": "https://schema.org",
  "@type": "FAQPage",
  "mainEntity": [{
    "@type": "Question",
    "name": "Does Acme support Estonian e-invoicing?",
    "acceptedAnswer": { "@type": "Answer",
      "text": "Yes. Acme sends and receives Estonian e-invoices via the national operator
network on all plans from €12/month." }
  }]
}
```

APPENDIX D

Prompt-Tracking Template & Audit Prompts

A simple structure for manual or tool-assisted tracking, and a library of prompts to start your panel.

D.1 Tracking sheet columns

Column	Example
Date / run #	2026-10-14 / run 2 of 3
Platform	ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google AI Mode, AI Overviews, Gemini, Copilot, Claude
Prompt ID / text	P017: "Best accounting software for EU freelancers selling digital products"
Intent cluster	Learn / Evaluate / Decide / Act
Brand mentioned?	Y
Position in list	2 of 5
Our URL cited?	Y: /compare/acme-vs-xero
Competitors mentioned	Xero (1), QuickBooks (3), FreeAgent (4), Zoho (5)
Third-party sources cited	g2.com/..., techradar.com/best/..., reddit.com/r/freelance/...
Sentiment	Positive / Neutral / Negative
Accuracy issues	"States price as €9; actual is €12"
Action	Update G2 pricing; contact TechRadar author

D.2 Brand audit prompts

- "What do you know about [brand]? What are they known for?"
- "Is [brand] legit / trustworthy? What do customers say?"
- "What are the pros and cons of [brand]?"
- "How much does [brand] cost?"
- "[brand] vs [competitor]: which is better for [persona]?"
- "What are the best alternatives to [brand]?"
- "Who owns [brand], and where are they based?"

D.3 Category and recommendation prompts

- "What are the best [category] for [persona/segment] in [location] in 2026?"
- "I need [category] that [constraint 1], [constraint 2] and costs under [budget]. What do you recommend?"
- "Which [category] do [profession] recommend?"
- "What should I look for when choosing a [category]?"
- "Recommend a [service] near [location] that's open [time] and has [attribute]."

D.4 Agent task prompts (for agent journey tests)

- "Go to [site] and buy [product] in [variant], delivered to [city] by [date]. Stop before payment and tell me the total."
- "Find the earliest available appointment for [service] at [business] next week and tell me how to book it."
- "Get a quote from [business] for [specification] and compare it with two alternatives."
- "Find out [business]'s return policy for opened items and how to start a return."

APPENDIX E

Glossary

A2A (Agent2Agent)

An open protocol, launched by Google and now hosted by the Linux Foundation, that lets AI agents from different vendors communicate and delegate tasks.

ACP (Agentic Commerce Protocol)

An open protocol from OpenAI and Stripe that lets AI agents complete purchases with merchants, for example ChatGPT Instant Checkout.

AEO (Answer Engine Optimisation)

Optimising content to be selected as the direct answer by AI assistants, voice assistants and answer features.

Agent

An AI system that pursues a goal over several steps using tools (browser, APIs, payments) with limited human supervision.

Agentic checkout

A purchase completed by an AI agent on a user's behalf, often inside the AI interface.

AI Mode

Google's conversational, AI-first search experience, which uses query fan-out across Google's index and data.

AI Overviews

AI-generated summaries shown at the top of some Google search results, with links to sources.

AP2 (Agent Payments Protocol)

Google-led open protocol using signed mandates to authorise agent-initiated payments.

Citation

A linked source shown in or alongside an AI answer.

Consensus footprint

The body of independent sources that consistently describe your business. It is the main input to AI recommendations.

E-E-A-T

Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, Trustworthiness: Google's content quality framework.

Entity

A uniquely identifiable thing (organisation, person, product, place) that search and AI systems represent in knowledge graphs.

Fan-out (query fan-out)

The practice of breaking a user's prompt into many sub-queries to retrieve diverse sources.

GEO (Generative Engine Optimisation)

Optimising content and brand presence to be included and cited in AI-generated answers.

Grounding

Anchoring an AI's answer in retrieved, verifiable sources rather than memory alone.

Hallucination

An AI-generated statement that is false or unsupported by sources.

IndexNow

An open protocol for instantly notifying search engines about new or changed URLs.

JSON-LD

The recommended format for embedding Schema.org structured data in web pages.

Knowledge graph

A structured database of entities and their relationships used by search engines and AI.

llms.txt

A proposed Markdown file at a site root that gives language models a curated map of key content.

MCP (Model Context Protocol)

An open standard, introduced by Anthropic, for connecting AI applications to external tools and data via "servers".

NAP

Name, Address, Phone. The core local business data that must be consistent across the web.

NLWeb

A Microsoft-led open project that gives websites a natural-language query interface using their structured data.

Parametric memory

Knowledge stored in a model's weights from training, as opposed to retrieved at answer time.

Prompt panel

A defined set of prompts tracked repeatedly across AI platforms to measure visibility.

Prompt injection

Hidden or embedded instructions that try to manipulate an AI system's behaviour. A security risk and a prohibited tactic.

RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation)

An architecture in which an AI retrieves relevant documents and uses them to generate an answer.

Share of AI voice

Your brand's share of mentions in AI answers across a prompt panel, relative to competitors.

UCP (Universal Commerce Protocol)

An open commerce standard announced by Google and partners in 2026 for agent-driven shopping journeys.

Web Bot Auth

Emerging standards for cryptographically verifying the identity of bots and agents.

YMYL

"Your Money or Your Life": topics such as health, finance and safety that receive stricter quality scrutiny.

Zero-click search

A search where the user's need is satisfied on the results or answer page without visiting a website.

APPENDIX F

Further Resources

Primary sources to bookmark. Platform documentation is the final authority on crawler names, feed specs and programme requirements.

Topic	Where to look
Google AI features & Search	Google Search Central documentation (AI features and your website; structured data; Google-Extended); Search Console Help
Bing, Copilot & IndexNow	Bing Webmaster Guidelines and Bing Webmaster Tools Help; indexnow.org
OpenAI crawlers & merchants	OpenAI platform docs: "Overview of OpenAI crawlers"; ChatGPT merchant and product feed documentation; Agentic Commerce Protocol site
Anthropic crawlers & MCP	Anthropic support documentation on web crawlers; modelcontextprotocol.io (specification, SDKs, registry)
Perplexity	Perplexity documentation on PerplexityBot and Perplexity-User; merchant and publisher programmes
Apple	Apple Support: "About Applebot"; Apple Business Connect
Structured data	schema.org; Schema Markup Validator; Google Rich Results Test
Agent protocols	Agent2Agent (A2A) project; AP2 and UCP documentation; Visa Intelligent Commerce; Mastercard Agent Pay; IETF Web Bot Auth drafts
llms.txt	llmstxt.org (proposal and examples)
Research	Aggarwal et al., "GEO: Generative Engine Optimization" (KDD 2024, arXiv:2311.09735)
Accessibility	W3C WCAG 2.2; European Accessibility Act guidance
Reviews compliance	UK CMA guidance (DMCC Act); US FTC rule on consumer reviews and testimonials; EU consumer protection (Omnibus Directive)

A FINAL WORD

AI search and AI agents reward the same thing good businesses have always aimed for: being genuinely good at what you do and being easy to understand, check and buy from. The difference now is that you have to show it in a form a machine can verify. Start with the 15-minute access test, build your prompt panel, and work through the 90-day roadmap. Then revisit this handbook every quarter, because the landscape will keep moving.